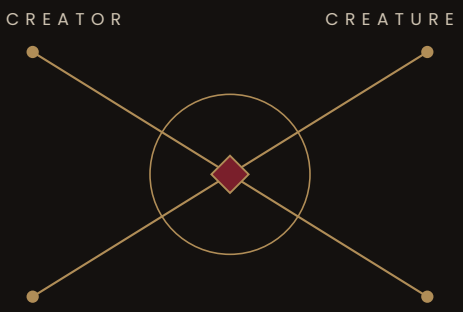
A DOCTORAL THESIS

ANTIGENESIS

Metis, the Unmade Bride, and the Theogonic Unconscious of Modernity in Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein; or, The Modern Prometheus*



OCTOBER 2026

Did I request thee, Maker, from my clay
To mould me man? Did I solicit thee
From darkness to promote me?

PARADISE LOST · X.743–745

Epigraph to the first edition of Frankenstein (1818)

THE ARGUMENT IN ORDER

Contents

Abstract 5

Note on Texts, Editions, and Citation 7

Introduction: The Problem of the Second Creation 9

Part One — Genealogies 13

1. The Promethean Archive: From Hesiod to Diodati 14

2. The Household of Reason: Godwin, Wollstonecraft, and Their Interlocutors 19

3. The Galvanic Moment: Natural Philosophy and the Ontology of Life 23

4. Sublime, Revolution, Monster 27

Part Two — Anatomies 30

5. Tabula Rasa with a Face: Epistemology and Formation 31

6. The Aesthetic A Priori of Recognition 34

7. Natality and the Irreversible: Responsibility after the Fact 38

8. The Chiasmus of Power: Biopolitics, Bare Life, and the Monstrous Double 41

Part Three — Comparanda 43

9. Mythic Comparanda: Narratives of Making 44

10. Gothic and Horror Comparanda: From Otranto to R.U.R. 48

Part Four — Antigenesis 52

11. The Orkney Laboratory: A Close Reading of the Unmaking 53

12. The Theogonic Unconscious 58

13. The Promethean Chiasmus 61

14. Three Refusals and the Promethean Remainder 64

15. The Pandoric Return: Afterlives of the Unmade Bride 67

Conclusion: The Author as Unmade Bride 70

Selected Bibliography 73

Keywords 79

PROLEGOMENA

Abstract

This thesis contends that the philosophical center of Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein; or, The Modern Prometheus* (1818; revised 1831) lies not in the novel's notorious act of making but in its least theorized act of unmaking: Victor Frankenstein's nocturnal destruction, on a barren island of the Orkneys, of the half-finished female creature he had covenanted to produce. Two centuries of criticism have read the novel under what I term its *Promethean bias*, locating the decisive event in the first creation and adjudicating it as transgression (the hubris of illicit knowledge), as abandonment (the failure of parental responsibility), or as appropriation (the masculine usurpation of birth). Reorganizing the text around its second, aborted creation, I advance the concept of antigenesis: the sovereign decision to withhold, abort, or unmake a creation that would complete a community for what has already been made. Antigenesis, I argue, is overdetermined by three anxieties that Victor's own deliberation articulates with diagnostic precision — a Malthusian anxiety of propagation ("a race of devils would be propagated upon the earth"), a Wollstonecraftian anxiety of female rational autonomy ("a thinking and reasoning animal" who "might refuse to comply with a compact made before her creation"), and a theogonic anxiety of succession ("the very existence of the species of man"). In its mythic grammar the novel accordingly rewrites not the theft of fire but the oldest pattern of sovereign self-preservation in the Hesiodic tradition: Zeus's swallowing of the pregnant Metis to forestall a successor, coupled with his motherless parturition of Athena. The subtitle's Prometheus is therefore a structural misdirection. Victor, who begins as Prometheus, ends in the positions of Zeus and of the chained archangel; the creature — discoverer of fire, anonymous benefactor, bound to solitude, consumed by perpetually renewed grief, and finally self-immolated — inherits the Promethean role. This exchange of positions, which I call the Promethean chiasmus, is traced across the novel's mythic, theological, dialectical, biopolitical, and narratological registers. Situating the text within its genealogies (Hesiod, Aeschylus, Plato, Ovid, Boccaccio, Pico, Shaftesbury, Milton, Rousseau, Locke, Condillac, Burke, Godwin, Wollstonecraft, Malthus, Galvani, Davy, Erasmus Darwin, and the Abernethy–Lawrence controversy over the nature of life), reading it through the philosophy of recognition, natality,

responsibility, and biopower, and testing it against mythic comparanda (Pandora, Eve, Asclepius, Pygmalion, the golem, Job) and Gothic-horror comparanda (from Walpole and Hoffmann to Stoker, Čapek, and Garland), the thesis identifies three modalities of refusal that the novel stages — sovereign, democratic, and sacrificial — none of which can annul the irreversibility of the first creation. What survives each is the Promethean remainder: the made being, the knowledge of its making, and the desire to make again. The thesis concludes that the adaptive afterlife of the novel constitutes a Pandoric return, a compulsive completion of the unmade bride oscillating between fantasies of total compliance and of total refusal, and that the text encrypts its author — the motherless daughter of two philosophers whose marriage was itself a compact contracted on account of her impending existence — as the female creature who refused the compact made before her creation and survived her unmaking by becoming the maker of the book.

PROLEGOMENA

Note on Texts, Editions, and Citation

Frankenstein exists in two authorial states that differ materially in ideology as well as in incident. The first edition appeared anonymously in three volumes on 1 January 1818 (London: Lackington, Hughes, Harding, Mavor, & Jones), in an impression of five hundred copies, with a dedication to William Godwin and an unsigned preface by Percy Bysshe Shelley. A two-volume second edition (1823), arranged by Godwin to capitalize on Richard Brinsley Peake's stage adaptation *Presumption; or, the Fate of Frankenstein*, was the first to bear Mary Shelley's name. The third edition (London: Colburn and Bentley, Standard Novels, 1831) is a substantive revision introduced by Mary Shelley's preface dated 15 October 1831. It converts Elizabeth from Victor's first cousin into a foundling of noble Milanese descent presented to him in childhood as "a pretty present," intensifies the vocabulary of destiny and providential prohibition, and, on Marilyn Butler's influential account (1993), retreats from the materialist physiology that the 1818 text shares with William Lawrence's side of the vitalist controversy. Charles E. Robinson's facsimile edition of the manuscripts (*The Frankenstein Notebooks*, 1996) and his edition of the draft (*The Original Frankenstein*, 2008) establish that Percy Shelley's interventions, though pervasive in local diction, amount to some four to five thousand words of a text of roughly seventy-two thousand; the conception, architecture, and argument are Mary Shelley's.

Neither text is treated here as authoritative to the exclusion of the other. Quotations follow the 1831 text unless a variant of 1818 is philosophically material, in which case it is marked. Because pagination varies across the many modern editions, the novel is cited by the volume and chapter of 1818 followed by the continuous chapter numbering of 1831, thus: (III.iii; ch. 20). The concordance is regular except at the opening, where the 1831 text divides the first chapter of 1818 in two.

1818 EDITION	1831 EDITION	PRINCIPAL CONTENT
Letters 1–4	Letters 1–4	Walton's Arctic frame

1818 EDITION	1831 EDITION	PRINCIPAL CONTENT
Vol. I, ch. 1	ch. 1–2	Genealogy; Elizabeth; the lightning-struck oak
Vol. I, ch. 2–7	ch. 3–8	Ingolstadt; the creation; William; Justine
Vol. II, ch. 1–9	ch. 9–17	Mer de Glace; the creature's narrative; the demand
Vol. III, ch. 1–7	ch. 18–24	England; Orkney; Evian; the Arctic; Walton's conclusion

Classical texts are cited by standard line, book, or Stephanus numbers; Milton by book and line; Kant's third *Critique* by section; Hegel's *Phenomenology* by the paragraph numbering of the Miller translation. Translations from Greek, Latin, French, German, and Italian are my own unless otherwise indicated. The novel's nameless protagonist is designated "the creature," the term he uses of himself when he first addresses his maker ("I am thy creature"); "monster," "fiend," "wretch," and "dæmon" are reserved for quotation and for analysis of the text's own economy of naming, which is itself part of its argument.

INTRODUCTION

The Problem of the Second Creation

I.1

The Promethean Bias

Every major interpretive tradition in the criticism of *Frankenstein* has been organized around a single scene: the "dreary night of November" on which Victor Frankenstein, "by the glimmer of the half-extinguished light," sees "the dull yellow eye of the creature open" (I.iv; ch. 5). The hermeneutic consequences of this fixation are so pervasive as to be nearly invisible. For the humanist tradition inaugurated by Harold Bloom's essay on the "new Prometheus" (1965) and consolidated in George Levine and U. C. Knoepflmacher's *The Endurance of Frankenstein* (1979), the scene is the locus of overreaching, a Romantic allegory of imagination outstripping the conditions of its embodiment; Paul Sherwin (1981) reads it as "creation as catastrophe," the moment at which the creative will discovers in its product an otherness it cannot assimilate. For the feminist tradition — Ellen Moers's identification of the novel as a birth myth (1976), Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar's reading of the creature as Mary Shelley's "monstrous Eve" (1979), Barbara Johnson's "My Monster/My Self" (1982), Mary Poovey's analysis of the proper lady's "hideous progeny" (1984), Margaret Homans's account of the novel's "circumvention of the maternal" (1986), and Anne K. Mellor's comprehensive critique of Victor's science as the masculine possession of a feminized nature (1988) — the scene is a usurpation of the womb, a male parturition whose horror is the horror of reproduction without women. For the political tradition — Lee Sterrenburg's reconstruction of the revolutionary iconography of the monster (1979), Franco Moretti's "dialectic of fear" in which the creature figures the proletariat (1983), Paul O'Flinn's materialist history of the novel's adaptive mutations (1983), Chris Baldick's genealogy of the monster as political metaphor (1987) — the scene is the birth of a collective subject that the dominant order calls into being and cannot acknowledge. For postcolonial and critical race criticism — Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak (1985), H. L. Malchow (1993), Elizabeth

Young (2008) — it is the fabrication of a racialized body whose "yellow skin" and "straight black lips" are legible within a nineteenth-century taxonomy of difference. For science studies — Marilyn Butler (1993), Sharon Ruston (2005) — it is a fictional experiment in the vitalist controversy; for the ethics of technology — Hans Jonas's framework of parental responsibility, Bruno Latour's injunction to "love your monsters" (2011) — it is the primal scene of abandonment, in which the maker flees from the made. Even Susan Stryker's transformative reading of the creature's rage as the affect of a body refused recognition (1994), and Denise Gigante's account of the creature as the aesthetic category of ugliness made flesh (2000), take their point of departure from what was made on that November night.

These readings are not wrong; collectively they constitute the most sophisticated body of criticism any English novel of its period has received. But they share a premise so fundamental that it has functioned less as a hypothesis than as a horizon: that the novel's decisive act is an act of making. I call this premise the *Promethean bias*, because it reads the novel through the subtitle's mythological index — the theft of fire, the fabrication of humankind from clay — and therefore assumes that the novel's ethical, political, and metaphysical stakes are concentrated in the question whether Victor should have made what he made, and how he ought to have treated it once made. Under the Promethean bias the destruction of the female creature in the third volume appears as a sequel, a consequence, or a variation: a second instance of the male birth fantasy (Homans), a plot device that motivates the creature's revenge and accelerates the narrative toward catastrophe. Mellor came closest to the scene's significance when she identified in it Victor's terror of an independent female will and of female sexual choice; yet even her acute analysis treats the episode as an instance of the novel's critique of masculine science rather than as its structural hinge. Donna Haraway's "Cyborg Manifesto" (1985) is among the very few theoretical texts to name the bride at all, and it does so in order to dismiss her: unlike Frankenstein's monster, Haraway's cyborg does not expect its father to save it through "the fabrication of a heterosexual mate." For Haraway the bride is the monster's nostalgia for an Edenic completion. This thesis reads her as something else entirely: the novel's point of maximum philosophical pressure, the place at which its mythic, political, and metaphysical vectors cross and exchange their values.

I.2

The Thesis of Antigenesis

The philosophical center of *Frankenstein*, I propose, is the scene in which Victor, alone in a hut on "one of the remotest of the Orkneys" (III.ii; ch. 19), looks up from the unfinished body of a female being, sees her intended mate grinning at the casement, and, "trembling with passion, tore to pieces the thing on which I was engaged" (III.iii; ch. 20). I name the act performed in that scene antigenesis: the sovereign decision to withhold, abort, or unmake a creation that would complete a community for what has already been made. Antigenesis is to be distinguished from non-creation (abstention from an act never begun), from destruction (the annihilation of an existing being), and from abandonment (the withdrawal of care from a being already made). It is the refusal of a *second* creation demanded by the existence of the first, and its object is not an individual but a possibility: a relation, a reproduction, a world.

The argument unfolds in seven propositions. First, antigenesis is the novel's decisive act, structurally and ethically, because it converts the created being's grievance into enmity and sets in motion every death that follows. Second, Victor's deliberation over the unfinished body is overdetermined by three convergent anxieties — of propagation, of female rational autonomy, and of species succession — which correspond respectively to the Malthusian critique of William Godwin's perfectibilism, to Mary Wollstonecraft's critique of Rousseau's designed woman, and to the Hesiodic logic of succession that will, after Darwin, be renamed the struggle for existence. Third, the novel's mythic grammar is accordingly not Promethean but Olympian: Victor reenacts Zeus's double act in the *Theogony*, the motherless birth of Athena from his own head and the swallowing of the pregnant Metis, goddess of cunning intelligence, to forestall a successor. Fourth, the novel therefore effects a *Promethean chiasmus* in which creator and creature exchange their mythic, theological, dialectical, and political positions, the crossing point of the X being the Orkney laboratory. Fifth, the novel tests three modalities by which Promethean power might be refused — the sovereign veto, the democratic veto, and the sacrificial self-veto — and shows that none of them can annul what I call the *Promethean remainder*: the persistence of the made being, of the knowledge of its making, and of the desire to make again. Sixth, the literary and adaptive afterlife of the novel is governed by a *Pandoric return*, a two-century repetition compulsion to complete the bride Mary Shelley left unmade. Seventh, the novel encrypts its author in the position of the unmade bride: the "thinking and reasoning animal" who refuses a compact made before her creation, and who survives her unmaking by becoming the maker of the text.

I.3

Method and Architecture

The method is a philosophical philology joined to a comparative mythopoetics, and its claims are of three evidentiary kinds, which are kept distinct throughout. Claims of *influence* rest on documentary grounds: the books the creature reads, the authors whom Mary Shelley's journals record her reading in 1814–17, the scientific debates conducted in her household, the texts the novel quotes. Claims of *homology* identify structural correspondences between the novel and later thought — Hegel's dialectic of recognition, Freud's primal horde, Arendt's natality, Foucault's biopower, Pateman's sexual contract — without any implication of prophecy; their warrant is that the novel and these theories respond to a common historical configuration, the post-revolutionary reorganization of life, labour, sexuality, and sovereignty, and that the novel registers in narrative form contradictions that theory would later conceptualize. Claims of *afterlife* concern the novel's reception and rewriting, which are treated not as a secondary history but as a symptomatic one: what a culture compulsively repeats is evidence of what a text left unresolved.

Part One (Genealogies) reconstructs the intellectual archive from which the novel was composed: the Promethean tradition from Hesiod to Diodati (Chapter 1); the household philosophy of Godwin and Wollstonecraft and their interlocutors Rousseau, Locke, Condillac, Volney, and Malthus (Chapter 2); the natural philosophy of galvanism and the vitalist controversy (Chapter 3); and the aesthetics and politics of the sublime and the revolutionary monster (Chapter 4). Part Two (Anatomies) analyses the novel's core philosophical tenets: its empiricist epistemology and theory of formation (Chapter 5); its demonstration of what I term the aesthetic a priori of recognition (Chapter 6); its ethics of natality and responsibility (Chapter 7); and its staging of the relation between sovereign power and biopower (Chapter 8). Part Three (Comparanda) situates the novel among mythic narratives of making (Chapter 9) and among works of Gothic and horror fiction from Walpole to Čapek (Chapter 10). Part Four (Antigenesis) develops the original thesis through a close reading of the Orkney episode (Chapter 11), a reconstruction of the novel's theogonic unconscious (Chapter 12), an anatomy of the Promethean chiasmus (Chapter 13), an analysis of the three refusals and the remainder they leave (Chapter 14), and an account of the Pandoric return in the novel's afterlives and in contemporary technoscientific governance (Chapter 15). The Conclusion reads the author into the place of the unmade bride.

I

PART ONE

Genealogies

CHAPTER 1
The Promethean Archive

CHAPTER 2
The Household of Reason

CHAPTER 3
The Galvanic Moment

CHAPTER 4
Sublime, Revolution, Monster

CHAPTER 1

The Promethean Archive

From Hesiod to Diodati

The subtitle *The Modern Prometheus* summons an archive more than two and a half millennia deep, and the precision with which the novel engages it has been consistently underestimated. Mary Shelley composed the novel in a circle that was, in the summer of 1816, the most concentrated site of Promethean reflection in Europe: Byron wrote his "Prometheus" at the Villa Diodati that July; Percy Shelley, by Thomas Medwin's later report, rendered Aeschylus' *Prometheus Bound* aloud for Byron there, and would complete *Prometheus Unbound* in 1819. The myth reached her not as a single narrative but as a palimpsest of incompatible versions, and the novel's originality lies in the way it activates their contradictions.

1.1

Forethought, Afterthought, and the Poisoned Gift

In Hesiod the Promethean story is inseparable from a story about women. The *Theogony* (507–616) and the *Works and Days* (42–105) narrate a sequence of exchanges between Prometheus and Zeus: the deceptive division of the sacrificial ox at Mekone, in which Prometheus allots bones wrapped in glistening fat to the gods and flesh to mortals; Zeus's retaliatory withholding of fire; Prometheus's theft of fire in a hollow fennel stalk; and Zeus's counter-gift, fashioned by Hephaestus from earth and water and adorned by the gods, "an evil in exchange for fire" (*anti puros*, *Works and Days* 57), a "beautiful evil" (*kalon kakon*, *Theogony* 585) from whom descends "the race of women" (*Theogony* 590). Prometheus is bound to a pillar, where an eagle devours by day a liver that regrows by night (*Theogony* 521–525). The myth is an economy of gifts and counter-gifts in which every benefit is paired with a cost, and the cost of fire is woman.

Jean-Pierre Vernant's structural analysis (1974) has shown that the Hesiodic myth defines the human condition by its intermediate position between gods and beasts, a position instituted by three correlated practices: sacrifice, which separates mortals from gods; agriculture, by which the means of life (*bios*) must be extracted from a

concealing earth; and marriage, by which humans must reproduce through the "belly" (*gastēr*) of women rather than spring from the soil. Before Pandora, Hesiod implies, men lived without labour, sickness, or women; after her they are mortal, sexed, and condemned to reproduce. Nicole Loraux (1981) has traced the persistence of the fantasy that precedes this condition in the Athenian ideology of autochthony, the birth of men from the earth without mothers. The relevance to *Frankenstein* is exact. Victor's project is a regression to the pre-Pandoric condition: a man born from the earth — or, in modernity's darker version, from the grave — without a woman. The creature's demand for a mate is a demand to enter the Pandoric condition, the human condition as Hesiod defines it, in which existence is sexual, reproductive, and therefore historical. And Victor's destruction of the female is a refusal of Pandora: the withholding of the counter-gift that, in Hesiod, completes the institution of humanity.

The names of the Titan brothers are equally consequential. Prometheus is "Forethought," Epimetheus "Afterthought": it is Epimetheus who, ignoring his brother's warning, accepts Pandora and understands his error only when the evil is already among men (*Works and Days* 85–89). Victor Frankenstein is an Epimethean Prometheus. His knowledge arrives systematically after the fact — "now that I had finished, the beauty of the dream vanished" (I.iv; ch. 5) — and his narrative to Walton is an extended exercise in afterthought. As Chapter 13 will argue, the one moment in which Victor exercises genuinely Promethean forethought is the Orkney deliberation, and it is precisely this act of foresight that precipitates the catastrophe.

1.2

Philanthropy, Secrecy, and Succession: Aeschylus

Prometheus Bound, attributed to Aeschylus (its authenticity has been doubted since Mark Griffith's study of 1977), transforms the Hesiodic trickster into a tragic benefactor. Its Prometheus suffers for his "man-loving disposition" (*philanthrōpos tropos*, 11, 28); his catalogue of gifts (436–506) — number, letters, the yoking of animals, ships, medicine, divination, metallurgy — culminates in the claim that "all arts for mortals come from Prometheus" (506). Among these gifts is one the tragedy treats with deliberate ambiguity: Prometheus stopped mortals from foreseeing their deaths by planting in them "blind hopes" (*tuphlas elpidas*, 250). The affective structure of Victor's ambition — the "enthusiastic frenzy" that sustains him through the charnel house while concealing from him the end to which it tends — is exactly this Promethean gift of blind hope.

Yet the play's dramatic engine is not the theft of fire. It is a secret about a marriage. Prometheus alone knows that Zeus, should he consummate a certain union, will beget a son mightier than his father who will cast him from his throne (755–770,

907–927); the wider tradition (Pindar, *Isthmian* 8) identifies the bride as the sea-nymph Thetis, whom Zeus, once warned, bestows on the mortal Peleus. Prometheus's leverage over the tyrant is knowledge of a reproduction that must not occur. The Promethean tradition thus already contains, at its tragic core, the structure that *Frankenstein* will place at its center: a sovereign threatened with supersession by the offspring of a marriage, and the decisive power of knowledge about which unions must be prevented. Victor's Orkney deliberation, which forecloses a union whose offspring would render "the very existence of the species of man a condition precarious," and the creature's answering threat against Victor's own marriage, are a modern recomposition of the Aeschylean secret.

1.3

Technē without Dikē: The Protagoras

In Plato's *Protagoras* (320c–322d) the sophist recounts the version of the myth that is, for the philosophical argument of *Frankenstein*, the most consequential of all. Epimetheus, charged with distributing capacities to living things, exhausts them on the animals and leaves humankind naked and defenceless; Prometheus remedies the deficiency by stealing from Hephaestus and Athena "technical wisdom together with fire" (*entechnos sophia sun puri*, 321d). Humans thereby acquire the arts of subsistence, but they lack the political art (*politikē technē*), and when they gather in cities they wrong one another and scatter. Zeus therefore dispatches Hermes to distribute to all humans alike *aidōs* (respect, the sense of shame before others) and *dikē* (justice), the conditions of living together (322c–d).

The *Protagoras* isolates with axiomatic clarity the deficiency that *Frankenstein* dramatizes. Victor possesses technical wisdom in the highest degree; what he lacks, and therefore cannot transmit, is the political art. The creature, remarkably, acquires a sense of justice on his own: reading Plutarch, he conceives an admiration for "the peaceable lawgivers, Numa, Solon, and Lycurgus, in preference to Romulus and Theseus" (II.vii; ch. 15). What no one supplies is the Hermetic distribution — the gift that, in Plato, must be given *to all alike* if it is to function at all. The creature possesses *dikē* without a polis in which to exercise it; Victor's community possesses a polis without extending its *aidōs* to the creature. Hermes — god of messages, thresholds, and interpretation — is the missing figure of the novel: the creature's self-education, conducted by eavesdropping through a chink in a cottage wall, is a hermeneutic act performed without a hermeneut.

1.4

The Plastic Prometheus and the Second Maker

A distinct strand of the tradition makes Prometheus the fabricator of humankind. Ovid's *Metamorphoses* (I.76–88) has the son of Iapetus mix earth with rainwater and mould it "in the likeness of the gods who govern all"; while the other animals stare at the ground, "he gave to man an uplifted face" (*os homini sublime dedit*) and bade him raise his countenance to the stars. Late antique sarcophagi depict Prometheus modelling human figures; Tertullian (*Apologeticum* 18.2) could call the Christian God, who formed man from the soil, the "true Prometheus"; Lucian's *Prometheus* stages a mock trial at which the Titan defends his fabrication of humans as an enrichment of the gods' own existence. Against this tradition the novel defines its creature by lapidary inversion. Ovid's Prometheus grants the sublime face; Victor's creature possesses the face from which every gaze is averted. Lucian's Prometheus defends his creation; Victor never defends his, and is instead arraigned by it.

Renaissance allegoresis made Prometheus the figure of a second, civilizing creation. Boccaccio's *Genealogia deorum gentilium* (IV.44), as Olga Raggio's classic study (1958) established, distinguishes the creation of natural man by God from the re-creation of that raw being by a second Prometheus, the sage who through instruction forms civil man. Pico della Mirandola's *Oration* (1486) has God tell Adam that he has been given "no fixed seat, no face of your own" (*nec propriam faciem*), so that he may fashion himself as "maker and moulder" (*plastes et fictor*) of his own being. In 1710 Shaftesbury transferred the figure to the author: the true poet is "a second maker; a just Prometheus under Jove." Three consequences follow. First, Victor is a first Prometheus who refuses to be the second: he performs the natural creation and abdicates the civil one, so that the creature must educate himself. Second, the creature is a Piconian being denied Pico's dignity: his nature is undetermined and his capacity for self-formation prodigious, but he possesses precisely what Pico's Adam lacks — a face that fixes his station. Third, the Shaftesburian equation of author and Prometheus sets the stage for the novel's final turn, in which the author herself occupies the place of the made.

1.5

The Electric and the Insurgent Prometheus

The adjective in the subtitle is not idle. In the last of his three essays of 1756 on the Lisbon earthquake, Kant called Benjamin Franklin, who had sought to disarm the thunderbolt, "the Prometheus of modern times"; the phrase marks the moment at which the stolen fire became electricity and the Titan an experimental philosopher.

Victor's conversion to natural philosophy is precipitated by the sight of a lightning-struck oak reduced to "a blasted stump" (I.i; ch. 2), and the novel's *modern* Prometheus is the electrical Prometheus of the Enlightenment.

Simultaneously the myth was becoming the vehicle of political and metaphysical insurgency. Goethe's ode "Prometheus" (c. 1774), published without his consent by F. H. Jacobi in 1785 and thereby made the detonator of the pantheism controversy, gives the Titan a voice of defiant self-sufficiency: "Hier sitz' ich, forme Menschen / Nach meinem Bilde, / Ein Geschlecht, das mir gleich sei, / Zu leiden, zu weinen" — here I sit, forming men in my own image, a race that shall be like me, to suffer, to weep, to enjoy and to rejoice, and to heed you not, as I. Hans Blumenberg's *Work on Myth* (1979) reads the ode as the paradigm of modern self-assertion working upon myth. Byron's "Prometheus," written at Diodati in July 1816, condenses the Romantic consensus: "Thy Godlike crime was to be kind, / To render with thy precepts less / The sum of human wretchedness." Percy Shelley's *Prometheus Unbound* (1820) completes the trajectory by making liberation depend on the Titan's revocation of his curse — "I wish no living thing to suffer pain" — and its preface declares Prometheus a more poetical character than Satan, "the type of the highest perfection of moral and intellectual nature."

Mary Shelley's subtitle intervenes in this lineage at the apex of its heroism and turns it against itself. The Romantic Prometheus is the rebel-benefactor who suffers for humankind against a tyrant. Mary Shelley's Prometheus is the maker who becomes a tyrant to what he makes. The subtitle functions as an irony whose full extent becomes visible only at the novel's end, when Byron's "Godlike crime" of kindness, Goethe's image of a made race destined "to suffer, to weep," and Percy Shelley's ideal of the curse revoked all prove to describe not Victor but the creature.

CHAPTER 2

The Household of Reason

Godwin, Wollstonecraft, and Their Interlocutors

Frankenstein is dedicated "To William Godwin, Author of *Political Justice*, *Caleb Williams*, &c." It is the most searching examination ever conducted of the philosophy of the household in which it was conceived, and its argument is unintelligible apart from the debates that household sustained.

2.1

Godwin: Necessity, Perfectibility, Pursuit

An Enquiry Concerning Political Justice (1793) rests on two doctrines. The doctrine of necessity holds that human actions are determined by antecedent causes, of which the most powerful are the impressions and circumstances through which character is formed; there is no innate depravity, only the depraving effect of institutions. The doctrine of perfectibility holds that, because character is formed by circumstance and opinion is governed by reason, humankind is susceptible of indefinite improvement through the progressive diffusion of truth. The creature's defence of himself on the Mer de Glace is a Godwinian syllogism: "I was benevolent and good; misery made me a fiend. Make me happy, and I shall again be virtuous" (II.ii; ch. 10). Percy Shelley's review of the novel, written in 1817 and published posthumously in 1832, grasped the point at once: "Treat a person ill, and he will become wicked." The novel tests the doctrine of necessity under laboratory conditions, so to speak, by producing a being with no history prior to its circumstances and then recording what those circumstances make of it.

Godwin's fiction supplied the novel's narrative architecture. *Caleb Williams* (1794) is the founding pursuit narrative of English fiction: the secretary Caleb discovers that his master Falkland is a murderer who has allowed two innocent men, the Hawkinses, to hang for his crime; Falkland pursues Caleb across England with the full apparatus of law and reputation, until the two are bound in a relation of mutual persecution in which the roles of hunter and hunted, accuser and accused, interpenetrate. The execution of the innocent Justine for William's murder repeats the Hawkinses' fate;

the final chase across the ice repeats the logic of the pursuit; and the creature's lament over Victor's corpse repeats Caleb's remorse at Falkland's collapse, the persecuted discovering that he has destroyed what he revered. Godwin's *St. Leon* (1799) supplied the figure of the alchemist made solitary by the very secret that was to have exalted him: Reginald de St. Leon, possessed of the philosopher's stone and the elixir of life, loses wife, children, and community to the isolating power of his knowledge.

The dedication carries a further charge. *Political Justice* had condemned marriage as "a monopoly, and the worst of monopolies"; yet when his daughter eloped in July 1814 with the married Percy Shelley, Godwin severed relations with her while continuing to solicit money from her lover. A novel in which a philosophical father produces a being and refuses to acknowledge it, while the being argues back in the father's own philosophical idiom, is dedicated to that father.

2.2

Wollstonecraft: The Rational Creature and the Made Woman

Mary Wollstonecraft died on 10 September 1797 of puerperal infection, eleven days after giving birth to the daughter who would write *Frankenstein*. The author was thus born into the death of her mother, a fact every account of the novel's maternal economy must confront. But Wollstonecraft's intellectual presence in the novel is more precise than an absent mother's. *A Vindication of the Rights of Woman* (1792) is in large part a polemic against Rousseau's *Émile*, and specifically against its fifth book, in which Rousseau designs Sophie, the wife appropriate to his ideal pupil, and declares that the whole education of women ought to be relative to men — to please them, to be useful to them, to make themselves loved and honoured by them. Wollstonecraft's rejoinder is that women are "rational creatures" whose formation must be governed by reason rather than by the requirements of a husband, and that a being formed for another's use is deformed by the very design that claims to perfect her.

The point bears directly on the Orkney episode. When Victor contemplates the unfinished female, his most philosophically charged fear is that she, "who in all probability was to become a thinking and reasoning animal, might refuse to comply with a compact made before her creation" (III.iii; ch. 20). This is the Wollstonecraftian problem in its purest form: the anxiety that a woman made for a purpose determined by men will prove to be a rational creature, and therefore not bound by that purpose. Victor's fear is the negative proof of Wollstonecraft's thesis.

2.3

Rousseau: The Genevan Inheritance

Victor is a citizen of Geneva, as Rousseau insisted on styling himself; the novel opens its family history in Rousseau's city and conducts its central dialogue in the Alps that Rousseau taught Europe to see. The first sentence of *Émile* — "Tout est bien sortant des mains de l'Auteur des choses: tout dégénère entre les mains de l'homme," everything is good as it leaves the hands of the Author of things, everything degenerates in the hands of man — is inverted by the novel with programmatic rigour: what leaves the hands of *this* author is already deformed, and the degeneration that follows is the work of human hands and human eyes. The *Discourse on the Origin of Inequality* (1755) provides the creature's anthropology. His first phase is that of Rousseau's natural man — solitary, frugal, moved by self-preservation (*amour de soi*) and by spontaneous pity; his decisive transformation occurs when he compares himself with the cottagers and with his own reflection, the comparison through which, in Rousseau, *amour-propre*, the self-love mediated by the regard of others, is born, and with it vanity, envy, and the desire for vengeance.

Rousseau's biography supplied a darker precedent. The *Confessions* acknowledge that he consigned his five children by Thérèse Levasseur to the Paris foundling hospital, a fact Voltaire had exposed anonymously in 1764. The century's great theorist of education was a father who abandoned his offspring. Victor, the Genevan who makes a being and flees from it, inherits Rousseau's contradiction as his own. Rousseau furnished, finally, the political form the creature's demand will take: the *Social Contract* (1762) founds legitimate association on a compact among free parties, and the agreement reached on the Mer de Glace is, as Chapter 11 will argue, a contract in Rousseau's sense whose hidden term is a woman who is not a party to it.

2.4

Locke, Condillac, Volney, Malthus

The creature's epistemology is that of the British and French empiricists. Locke's *Essay Concerning Human Understanding* (1690), which Mary Shelley's journal records her reading during the period of composition, supposes the mind at birth to be "white paper, void of all characters," furnished by sensation and reflection; Condillac's *Traité des sensations* (1754) imagines a statue animated sense by sense, beginning with smell. The creature's account of his first days is a narrative realization of this thought experiment. Volney's *Les Ruines, ou Méditation sur les révolutions des empires* (1791), which the creature hears Felix read to Safie, supplies his universal history, and with it

his first lesson in political grief: he weeps "with Safie over the hapless fate" of the original inhabitants of the Americas (II.v; ch. 13).

The most consequential and least noticed interlocutor of the household is Thomas Robert Malthus, whose *Essay on the Principle of Population* (1798) was composed expressly to refute Godwin and Condorcet. Against the doctrine of perfectibility Malthus set an arithmetic: "Population, when unchecked, increases in a geometrical ratio. Subsistence increases only in an arithmetical ratio." Misery and vice are therefore not the products of bad institutions but the checks that nature necessarily imposes on reproduction. In the second edition (1803) Malthus added a passage, later suppressed, that reads as a précis of the creature's condition:

> A man who is born into a world already possessed, if he cannot get subsistence from his parents on whom he has a just demand, and if the society do not want his labour, has no claim of right to the smallest portion of food, and, in fact, has no business to be where he is. At nature's mighty feast there is no vacant cover for him. She tells him to be gone, and will quickly execute her own orders, if he do not work upon the compassion of some of her guests.

The correspondences are exact. The creature is born into a world already possessed: "I knew that I possessed no money, no friends, no kind of property" (II.v; ch. 13). He has a just demand on his parent and formulates it in precisely those terms: "I demand it of you as a right which you must not refuse to concede" (II.ix; ch. 17). His one strategy for admission to the human table is to work upon the compassion of a guest — the blind De Lacey — and it fails. The Shelley household was militantly anti-Malthusian; Percy Shelley would declare in the preface to *Prometheus Unbound* that he had "rather be damned with Plato and Lord Bacon, than go to Heaven with Paley and Malthus." The novel's decision to arm Victor, at the moment of antigenesis, with a Malthusian argument about propagation is therefore a decision with a precise ideological valence. The Godwin–Malthus controversy, I shall argue, is the hidden dialectic of the Orkney scene.

CHAPTER 3

The Galvanic Moment

Natural Philosophy and the Ontology of Life

The novel's science is not decorative pseudo-science but a precise index of the most contested question in the natural philosophy of its decade: what life is, and whether it can be produced.

3.1

The Repressed Alchemical Origin

Victor's intellectual biography begins with a misreading. At thirteen he discovers a volume of Cornelius Agrippa, whose *De occulta philosophia* (1533) his father dismisses as "sad trash" (I.i; ch. 2); he proceeds to Paracelsus and Albertus Magnus and conceives the ambition to discover the elixir of life and to "banish disease from the human frame." At Ingolstadt the contemptuous Krempe dismisses these authors as "exploded systems," while the urbane Waldman reconciles him to modern chemistry by describing its practitioners as having achieved what the alchemists only promised. The alchemical origin is not superseded but repressed, and it returns. The pseudo-Paracelsian *De natura rerum* (1537) contains the period's most notorious recipe for a homunculus: human semen sealed in a vessel and incubated in horse dung for forty days, producing a small transparent man generated without any woman. Alchemy transmitted to modern science not only the dream of immortality but the specific fantasy of male generation, reproduction from the father alone. Goethe would dramatize the fantasy in the laboratory homunculus of *Faust II* (1832); Mary Shelley returned to Agrippa in "The Mortal Immortal" (1833), whose narrator drinks his master's elixir and is condemned to outlive everyone he loves. Victor's modern science is the alchemical male birth executed by modern means.

3.2

Galvani, Aldini, Davy, Darwin

The means are electrical. Luigi Galvani's *De viribus electricitatis in motu musculari commentarius* (1791) reported that the legs of dissected frogs contracted under electrical stimulation and proposed an intrinsic "animal electricity"; Alessandro Volta, rejecting the hypothesis, devised the voltaic pile (1800) to show that the current arose from the contact of dissimilar metals. The dispute made the relation between electricity and vitality the most fashionable question in European science. In January 1803 Galvani's nephew Giovanni Aldini applied current to the body of George Forster, newly hanged at Newgate, before an audience of surgeons; by the published accounts the jaw quivered, an eye opened, and a hand rose and clenched. In November 1818, ten months after the novel's publication, Andrew Ure performed comparable experiments in Glasgow on the executed murderer Matthew Clydesdale. Alexander von Humboldt and Johann Wilhelm Ritter galvanized their own bodies. Mary Shelley's 1831 introduction records the conversations at Diodati in which "galvanism had given token of such things," and imagines that "the component parts of a creature might be manufactured, brought together, and endued with vital warmth."

Humphry Davy supplied the rhetoric of mastery. His *Discourse Introductory to a Course of Lectures on Chemistry* (1802) celebrated chemistry for bestowing on man "powers which may be almost called creative," enabling him to interrogate nature "not simply as a scholar … but rather as a master, active with his own instruments." Mary Shelley's journal records her reading Davy's *Elements of Chemical Philosophy* in October 1816, and Waldman's lecture — the moderns "penetrate into the recesses of nature, and shew how she works in her hiding places … they can command the thunders of heaven, mimic the earthquake, and even mock the invisible world with its own shadows" (I.ii; ch. 3) — is a condensed Davyan manifesto. Erasmus Darwin supplied the speculative biology. Percy Shelley's preface opens by observing that the event of the fiction "has been supposed, by Dr. Darwin, and some of the physiological writers of Germany, as not of impossible occurrence"; the 1831 introduction recalls Darwin's having preserved "a piece of vermicelli in a glass case, till by some extraordinary means it began to move with voluntary motion" — a misremembering, as critics have long noted, of the *vorticella*, the microscopic wheel-animalcule that the notes to *The Temple of Nature* (1803) describe as reviving after desiccation.

The "physiological writers of Germany" plausibly include Johann Friedrich Blumenbach, whose doctrine of the *Bildungstrieb* (1781), a formative drive that organizes matter into living form, Kant adopted in the third *Critique*. It is a fact of considerable significance for the novel's racial semiotics that the same Blumenbach was the period's foremost classifier of human varieties and, in the third edition of *De*

generis humani varietate nativa (1795), the coiner of the term "Caucasian." The discourse of vitality and the discourse of race converge in a single figure, as they converge in the creature's body, whose "yellow skin" and "straight black lips" are at once signs of imperfect animation and of racial difference.

3.3

The Vitalist Controversy and Kant's Blade of Grass

Between 1814 and 1819 London's medical establishment was convulsed by a dispute between John Abernethy and his former pupil William Lawrence. Abernethy's Hunterian lectures (1814) argued that life is a subtle, mobile, invisible substance superadded to organized structure and analogous to electricity; Lawrence, in lectures of 1816 and in his *Lectures on Physiology, Zoology, and the Natural History of Man* (1819), replied that life is nothing but the assemblage of the functions of organized bodies and requires no superadded principle. Lawrence's materialism provoked charges of irreligion, and in 1822 the Court of Chancery declined to protect his copyright on the ground that the work contradicted Scripture. Lawrence was the Shelleys' physician. Marilyn Butler has argued that the 1818 text is aligned with his materialism and that the 1831 revisions, which reframe Victor's project in the language of destiny and transgression, represent a retreat toward religious respectability.

The philosophical stakes are sharpened by Kant's *Critique of the Power of Judgment* (1790). An organism, Kant argues, is a natural end, a being whose parts are reciprocally cause and effect of one another and of the whole, so that it is "organized and self-organizing" (§65); its production can never be explained by mechanical laws alone, and it is absurd to hope that a Newton may yet arise who could make intelligible the generation of so much as a blade of grass according to laws no intention has ordered (§75). Victor is the Newton of the blade of grass whom Kant declared impossible, and his creature is the antinomy of teleological judgment (§§70–71) made flesh: a being assembled mechanically, part by part, from "the dissecting room and the slaughter-house," which nevertheless lives as a self-organizing whole. The creature neither refutes Kant nor confirms him. He embodies the contradiction between mechanism and teleology without resolving it, which is one reason he is unassimilable to every category his observers bring to him.

A further detail anticipates a specifically modern form of technological agency. Victor reports that, "as the minuteness of the parts formed a great hindrance to my speed," he resolved to make the being "of a gigantic stature; that is to say, about eight feet in height, and proportionably large" (I.iii; ch. 4). The creature's most socially consequential attribute, his monstrous size, is not a choice of ends but an artefact of procedural convenience. Form follows the requirements of technique: the first

fabricated being of modern fiction is shaped less by its maker's intention than by the affordances of his method.

3.4

Ingolstadt and the Illuminist Shadow

Victor studies at Ingolstadt, whose university had removed to Landshut in 1800 but which retained for Mary Shelley's generation a specific connotation. In 1776 Adam Weishaupt, professor of canon law there, founded the Order of the Illuminati; the Abbé Barruel's *Mémoires pour servir à l'histoire du jacobinisme* (1797–98) traced the French Revolution to its conspiracy, and Mary Shelley's journal records Percy Shelley reading Barruel during the elopement journey of 1814. To set the creation at Ingolstadt was to place the laboratory at the intersection of Enlightenment science, secret association, and revolution. The production of a new being is coded, at the level of setting, as the production of a new political order whose makers cannot control it.

CHAPTER 4

Sublime, Revolution, Monster

4.1

Burke's Physiology of Terror and the Kantian Remainder

Edmund Burke's *Philosophical Enquiry into the Origin of Our Ideas of the Sublime and Beautiful* (1757) grounded aesthetics in physiology. "Whatever is fitted in any sort to excite the ideas of pain, and danger, that is to say, whatever is in any sort terrible … is a source of the sublime"; obscurity, power, privation, vastness, and infinity produce a delightful horror when the danger is held at a distance. Beauty, by contrast, inheres in the small, the smooth, the delicate, and the gradually varied; it inspires love rather than awe, and Burke's gendering of the two categories is explicit — "we submit to what we admire, but we love what submits to us." Wollstonecraft's *Vindication of the Rights of Men* (1790) had already attacked this aesthetic as the ideological armature of a politics of deference.

Victor's creature is an experiment in Burkean categories that yields a result for which Burke has no name. Victor selected the features as beautiful; he made the frame gigantic. The creature therefore combines the parts of beauty with the scale of the sublime, and the compound is neither: "Beautiful!—Great God! His yellow skin scarcely covered the work of muscles and arteries beneath … but these luxuriances only formed a more horrid contrast with his watery eyes" (I.iv; ch. 5). The method has a classical pedigree that the novel silently invokes. Cicero (*De inventione* II.1–3) and Pliny (*Natural History* 35.64) tell how Zeuxis, commissioned to paint Helen, selected the most beautiful features of five maidens of Croton and combined them into an ideal. Victor applies the Zeuxian method of ideal composition to corpses, and the result is not Helen but her negation. Beauty-by-selection collapses when realized in flesh, because beauty, as Burke and Kant in different ways insist, is a property of wholes that cannot be assembled from beautiful parts. Denise Gigante (2000) has shown that the creature introduces into Romantic aesthetics the category of the ugly, which the dichotomy of sublime and beautiful had excluded; I would add that the ugliness is produced precisely by the attempt to compose beauty mechanically.

Kant's analytic of the sublime (1790) redeems the terror that Burke left physiological. Before the mathematically vast or the dynamically overwhelming, imagination fails, and in that failure reason discovers its own supersensible vocation, superior to any nature that could crush the body. The scene on the Mer de Glace is constructed as a Kantian ascent and then interrupted. Victor climbs to the glacier seeking the elevation that "filled me with a sublime ecstasy that gave wings to the soul" (II.ii; ch. 10), and at its summit the creature appears, "advancing towards me with superhuman speed," and begins to speak. The sublime does not return the subject to the dignity of reason; it returns as a person with a grievance. The supersensible vocation that Kant locates in the subject is relocated, in the novel, in the object that refuses to remain an object.

4.2

The Revolutionary Monster

The vocabulary of monstrosity was, in the 1790s, the primary idiom of counter-revolutionary rhetoric. Burke's *Reflections on the Revolution in France* (1790) staged the Revolution as a monstrous tragi-comic scene and the people as a "swinish multitude"; his first *Letter on a Regicide Peace* (1796) imagined that "out of the tomb of the murdered monarchy in France has arisen a vast, tremendous, unformed spectre." Barruel made the Revolution the monstrous offspring of an Illuminist conspiracy. On the other side, Wollstonecraft's *Historical and Moral View of the Origin and Progress of the French Revolution* (1794) argued that the violence of the Terror was the product of the oppression that had deformed the oppressed — an aetiology identical in structure to the creature's defence of himself. Lee Sterrenburg (1979) showed that the novel's vocabulary is saturated with this iconography; the novel speaks with both voices, presenting a monster whose crimes are real and whose crimes have been made.

The political career of the creature began almost at once. On 16 March 1824 George Canning, opposing the immediate emancipation of enslaved people in the West Indies, warned the House of Commons that to free them without preparation "would be to raise up a creature resembling the splendid fiction of a recent romance." In *Mary Barton* (1848) Elizabeth Gaskell declared that "the actions of the uneducated seem to me typified in those of Frankenstein, that monster of many human qualities, ungifted with a soul." The creature has since figured the Jacobin crowd, the enslaved, the Irish, the proletariat, the colonized, and, in Elizabeth Young's account of *Black Frankenstein* (2008), an African American subject who both suffers and appropriates the trope. Mary Shelley's achievement was to give the monster of political rhetoric the one thing the rhetoric denied it: a voice capable of arguing its own case.

4.3

Topographies: Mont Blanc, the Mer de Glace, the Pole

The novel's landscapes are not backdrops but argumentative sites. In July 1816 Mary and Percy Shelley visited Chamonix and the Mer de Glace; their *History of a Six Weeks' Tour* (1817) includes Percy's "Mont Blanc," which addresses the mountain as the dwelling of "the secret Strength of things / Which governs thought, and to the infinite dome / Of Heaven is as a law." The novel places at precisely this site, where Romantic poetry located the law-giving power of nature, the creature's demand for justice. The secret strength of things is answered by a being who demands a law.

The Arctic frame performs a parallel displacement. Walton sails north in the belief, current in the expansionist geography of the period and promoted at the Admiralty by John Barrow, that beyond the ice lies an open polar sea, a region of perpetual light "surpassing in wonders and in beauty every region hitherto discovered on the habitable globe," where he may discover "the wondrous power which attracts the needle" (Letter 1). The first British expeditions of the new era of Arctic exploration sailed in 1818, the year of the novel's publication. Wollstonecraft's *Letters Written during a Short Residence in Sweden, Norway, and Denmark* (1796), her most admired book, had already made the northern landscape a site of maternal reflection and philosophical solitude. The novel converts Walton's Promethean north into the theatre of the final antigenesis: it is on the ice that the creature resolves to destroy himself so that no one may make another like him, and on the ice that Walton's crew compels the abandonment of the Promethean quest.

II

PART TWO

Anatomies

CHAPTER 5
Tabula Rasa with a Face

CHAPTER 6
The Aesthetic A Priori of Recognition

CHAPTER 7
Natality and the Irreversible

CHAPTER 8
The Chiasmus of Power

CHAPTER 5

Tabula Rasa with a Face

Epistemology and Formation

5.1

Sensation and the Statue

The creature's narrative opens with an empiricist genesis. "A strange multiplicity of sensations seized me, and I saw, felt, heard, and smelt, at the same time; and it was, indeed, a long time before I learned to distinguish between the operations of my various senses" (II.iii; ch. 11). Light presses upon his nerves until he closes his eyes; darkness troubles him; heat, cold, hunger, and thirst are discriminated one by one; the moon gives him his first pleasure in an object, birdsong his first desire to imitate. This is Locke's white paper receiving its first characters and Condillac's statue awakened by successive senses. Yet the novel introduces into the empiricist thought experiment a variable that its philosophical originals bracketed. Condillac's statue perceives; it is never perceived. Locke's infant is furnished by experience; the question of how it appears to others does not arise. The creature is a *tabula rasa with a face*: a subject whose mind is blank but whose body is already inscribed, legible to every observer before he can read anything himself. His epistemology is complete, and complete in a remarkably short time — he is not yet two years old when he delivers his autobiography on the Mer de Glace — but his ontology is social, and determined in advance by his visibility. The novel's implicit correction of empiricism is that the knowing subject is always also an object of other subjects' perception, and that what the senses give the self is less consequential than what others' senses give them of it.

5.2

The Creature's Library and the Fifth Book

In a leather portmanteau found in the woods the creature discovers three books — *Paradise Lost*, a volume of Plutarch's *Lives*, and *The Sorrows of Young Werther* — to which must be added Volney's *Ruins*, heard through the cottage wall. Together they constitute a complete curriculum of Enlightenment formation in four registers: the theological and cosmogonic (Milton), which gives him a model for his own origin and the vocabulary of creator and creature; the political (Plutarch), which gives him the lawgivers and the idea of a commonwealth; the affective (Goethe), which gives him the language of sensibility and the precedent of a solitary suicide; and the historical (Volney), which gives him the spectacle of empires rising and falling and the first object of his political compassion. It is a Bildungsroman in miniature, contemporary in conception with Goethe's *Wilhelm Meisters Lehrjahre* (1795–96), and it succeeds intellectually: the creature becomes the most eloquent speaker in the novel.

There is, however, a fifth book. In the pocket of the coat he took from Victor's laboratory the creature finds Victor's journal of "the four months that preceded my creation," in which "every thing is related … which bears reference to my accursed origin" and "the minutest description of my odious and loathsome person is given" (II.vii; ch. 15). He is the first being in literature to read the technical protocol of his own manufacture. The fifth book negates the other four: each of the humanist narratives offered him a place in a story of meaning, and the record of his origin reveals that he was produced by a procedure. The scene anticipates a specifically modern predicament — that of the subject who reads his own genesis in the language of technique — and its affect is the creature's first curse upon his maker: "Hateful day when I received life!"

The library has a further, social dimension that Joyce Zonana (1991) and Spivak (1985) have brought into focus. The creature learns French in parallel with Safie, the daughter of a Turkish merchant and a Christian Arab mother, who arrives at the cottage unable to speak the language of her lover. His instruction is her instruction; he acquires language as a foreign woman acquires it, and the copies of her letters that he gives Victor as proof of his tale form the innermost core of the novel's nested narratives. The creature's first co-pupil is a woman being formed for a man, and the novel has already, in its central chamber, staged the education of the female creature it will refuse to complete.

5.3

Feral Analogues

The eighteenth century conducted its experiments on the natural man with real children. Peter the Wild Boy, found in the woods near Hamelin in 1725 and brought to the court of George I, was the occasion of Defoe's *Mere Nature Delineated* (1726) and of Lord Monboddo's speculations in *Of the Origin and Progress of Language* (1773–92), which also entertained the humanity of the orang-utan, a question Rousseau had raised in the tenth note to the *Second Discourse*. In 1800 a boy captured in the forests of Aveyron was entrusted to the physician Jean-Marc-Gaspard Itard, whose reports (1801, 1806; English translation 1802) recorded both the pupil's progress in sensibility and his persistent failure to acquire speech. Itard named the boy Victor. There is no evidence that Mary Shelley knew the name, and the coincidence must be registered as such; but the structural relation is instructive. The documented feral children failed to acquire full language. Mary Shelley grants her creature precisely the success the empirical cases denied, and thereby converts the experiment into a counterfactual that isolates its true variable. If the natural man acquires language, reason, sensibility, and a sense of justice, and is refused nonetheless, then the cause of his exclusion is not his deficiency but the regard of others. The novel holds every faculty constant and varies only recognition.

CHAPTER 6

The Aesthetic A Priori of Recognition

The central philosophical demonstration of *Frankenstein*, I contend, is that ethical recognition is conditioned by aesthetic perception: before a being can be acknowledged as a subject of claims, it must be perceived in a form that permits acknowledgement, and that form is aesthetic before it is moral. I call this condition the *aesthetic a priori of recognition*.

6.1

Physiognomy in the Family Circle

Johann Kaspar Lavater's *Physiognomische Fragmente* (1775–78) codified for the late eighteenth century the doctrine that the outward form of the face is the legible sign of inward character. The doctrine reached England through the intimate circle of Mary Shelley's parents. Thomas Holcroft, Godwin's closest friend, published a translation in 1789; Henry Fuseli, Lavater's friend and the English translator of his *Aphorisms on Man* (1788), was involved in the lavish rival edition of 1789–98. Fuseli was the object of Wollstonecraft's unrequited attachment in 1792, and his painting *The Nightmare* (1781) — an incubus crouched upon a sleeping woman flung back across a bed — supplies the visual template for Elizabeth's corpse, "thrown across the bed, her head hanging down, and her pale and distorted features half covered by her hair" (III.vi; ch. 23).

The creature's fate is physiognomic, and the novel's critique of physiognomy is its circularity. Every human being who sees him reads evil in his face, and his treatment in consequence of that reading produces the evil that was read. Physiognomy appears not as a descriptive science but as a performative one, a self-fulfilling prophecy that manufactures the character it claims to decipher. Kant had concluded the aesthetic part of the third *Critique* with the proposition that the beautiful is the symbol of the morally good (§59). The creature is the refutation of the converse: a moral beauty — benevolence, gratitude, sympathy, a passion for justice — that possesses no aesthetic symbol and is therefore socially invisible.

6.2

The Pool: Narcissus, Eve, and the Inverted Mirror Stage

"I had admired the perfect forms of my cottagers … but how was I terrified, when I viewed myself in a transparent pool! At first I started back, unable to believe that it was indeed I who was reflected in the mirror; and when I became fully convinced that I was in reality the monster that I am, I was filled with the bitterest sensations of despondence and mortification" (II.iv; ch. 12). The scene inverts two canonical reflections. Ovid's Narcissus (*Metamorphoses* III) falls in love with his image in the pool; Milton's Eve, newly created, bends over a lake, sees a shape that returns her gaze, and "pin'd with vain desire" (*Paradise Lost* IV.466) until a voice leads her to Adam. Gilbert and Gubar noticed the Miltonic echo; its full significance becomes clear when the scene is set against Jacques Lacan's account of the mirror stage (1949), in which the infant greets its specular image with jubilation, assuming in it an ideal unity its uncoordinated body does not yet possess — a constitutive *méconnaissance*. The creature's specular moment is the exact negative. It is not a misrecognition that anticipates an ideal but an accurate recognition that ratifies a verdict: he sees himself as others have seen him, and consents to their sight. The phrase "the monster that I am" marks the moment at which a social designation becomes a self-designation. It is also, in Rousseau's terms, the moment of comparison — with the "perfect forms" of the cottagers — in which *amour-propre* is born.

The same internalization recurs, with a significance criticism has not registered, in the case of Justine Moritz. Pressed by her confessor to admit a crime she did not commit, under threat of excommunication, she yields: "I almost began to think that I was the monster that he said I was" (I.vii; ch. 8). The word the creature applies to himself at the pool is applied to herself by the innocent woman he has framed. The novel's two scapegoats share a vocabulary of internalized monstrosity, and the female victim is made monstrous by the same mechanism of social designation that makes the creature.

6.3

The Look, the Face, the Frame

Sartre's analysis of the look (*le regard*) in *Being and Nothingness* (1943) describes how the gaze of another transforms me into an object and how, in shame, I recognize that I am that object. Frantz Fanon's *Black Skin, White Masks* (1952) radicalizes the analysis in the scene in which a child's cry — "Look, a Negro!" — fixes him in his body and sutures him to a historical-racial schema he did not choose. The creature's meeting with William Frankenstein is Fanon's scene avant la lettre: the child shrieks "Monster!

Ugly wretch! you wish to eat me, and tear me to pieces—You are an ogre" (II.viii; ch. 16), assigning the creature at a glance to a category of fairy-tale predation, and the creature's murderous response realizes the category the child imposed. Rosemarie Garland-Thomson's work on disability and staring (1997; 2009) supplies a further frame: the creature is the paradigmatic stared-at body, whose difference is so salient that it overwrites every other attribute and authorizes every act of exclusion.

The deepest challenge the novel poses is to the ethics of Emmanuel Levinas. For Levinas (*Totality and Infinity*, 1961) the face of the Other is the primordial site of ethics: before any knowledge, the face addresses me with the command not to kill. *Frankenstein* is a sustained counter-example. The creature's face commands nothing but flight and violence; its address is heard as a threat. Judith Butler's *Precarious Life* (2004) and *Frames of War* (2009) argue that the face does not operate prior to culture but within frames that determine which lives are recognized as lives and which deaths are grievable. The novel demonstrates the thesis in narrative form, and it supplies the decisive control case: the blind De Lacey. Deprived of sight, the old man receives the creature's voice with courtesy and kindness; their conversation is the only scene of unconditional hospitality in the book, an instance of what Jacques Derrida (*Of Hospitality*, 1997) calls the welcome extended to the *arrivant* before knowledge of who or what arrives. The moment Felix, Safie, and Agatha enter, sight returns, and hospitality turns into its etymological twin: Felix dashes the creature to the ground and strikes him with a stick. What is received through the voice is expelled through the eye. The aesthetic a priori is isolated with experimental rigour. Later fictions institutionalize it: Philip K. Dick's *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968) gates personhood behind a measured empathic response, and Kazuo Ishiguro's *Never Let Me Go* (2005) imagines cloned children whose artworks are collected to prove that they possess inner lives at all.

Susan Stryker's "My Words to Victor Frankenstein above the Village of Chamounix" (1994) appropriates the creature's voice to articulate a transgender rage at a medical and social order that constructs bodies and then refuses to recognize them. Her reading confirms the analysis offered here: the creature's rage is not the expression of an innate violence but the affect proper to a body that has been made, judged by its appearance, and denied the frame within which it could be recognized as a subject.

6.4

Lordship and Bondage

Hegel's *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807; §§178–196) derives self-consciousness from the struggle for recognition: each consciousness seeks to be recognized by another, the struggle issues in the relation of lord and bondsman, and the dialectic reverses that relation, since the lord, recognized only by one he does not recognize, achieves no satisfaction, while the bondsman, through fear and labour, attains a truer self-consciousness. Mary Shelley did not read Hegel, but the novel enacts the reversal in explicit terms. After the destruction of the female the creature addresses his maker: "Slave, I before reasoned with you, but you have proved yourself unworthy of my condescension. … You are my creator, but I am your master;—obey!" (III.iii; ch. 20). The struggle for recognition has become a struggle over reproduction, and its reversal is precipitated by antigenesis.

Fichte's *Foundations of Natural Right* (1796–97) argued that a finite rational being becomes conscious of its freedom only when summoned (*aufgefordert*) to free activity by another rational being. The creature is never summoned except negatively: "Begone, vile insect!" (II.ii; ch. 10). Axel Honneth's reconstruction of the theory (*The Struggle for Recognition*, 1992) distinguishes three spheres of recognition — love, rights, and solidarity — whose denial produces three forms of injury. The creature is denied each in turn: love by his maker, who flees him, and by the mate who is unmade; rights by a legal order in which he has no standing; solidarity by the community of the cottage, whose esteem he seeks through anonymous service. *Frankenstein* is a phenomenology of misrecognition, and its catastrophe is the convergence of all three denials upon a being who had, by every intellectual measure, earned all three.

CHAPTER 7

Natality and the Irreversible

Responsibility after the Fact

7.1

Jonas and the Newborn

Hans Jonas's *The Imperative of Responsibility* (1979) proposed an ethics for the technological age grounded in an archetype: the responsibility of the parent for the newborn, whose mere breathing addresses to the world an unconditional demand for care. The obligation, Jonas insists, is immediately evident — "look and you know." The creation scene is the archetypal scene of this obligation refused. The creature's first gestures are an infant's: he lifts the curtain of the bed, mutters "inarticulate sounds," grins, and stretches out a hand "seemingly to detain me" (I.iv; ch. 5). Victor looks, and does not know; or rather, he knows, and flees: "Unable to endure the aspect of the being I had created, I rushed out of the room."

Jonas also proposed a heuristics of fear, by which the imagination of the worst consequences of technological action is to guide present restraint, and an obligation toward future generations that takes precedence over present interest. The Orkney deliberation is a precocious exercise of this heuristics — Victor imagines "everlasting generations" cursed by his act — and the novel's moral crux is that the heuristics of fear is mobilized *against* the newborn's kind. Victor honours the abstract responsibility to future humanity by violating the concrete responsibility to the being he has already made. The novel does not resolve the conflict between these two responsibilities; it exposes the cost of resolving it unilaterally.

7.2

Arendt: Natality without Plurality

Hannah Arendt's *The Human Condition* (1958) opens with a prologue that might serve as a gloss on the novel: it notes the scientific ambition to create life in the test tube and to produce superior human beings, and diagnoses in it a "rebellion against human existence as it has been given." Arendt's central concept, natality, designates the

capacity for beginning that every birth brings into the world: because each newcomer is unique, each can begin something new, and action, the highest of human capacities, is the actualization of this capacity in the presence of others. Action requires plurality — the fact that "men, not Man," inhabit the earth — and it requires a space of appearance in which speech and deed can be seen and heard.

The creature is pure natality without plurality. He is the most radical beginning imaginable — a being without precedent, kind, or genealogy — and he possesses in abundance the capacities for speech and action that Arendt makes definitive of the human. What he lacks is any space of appearance. His one great public speech is addressed to a single listener in a mountain hut; his acts of benevolence are performed invisibly, by night; his appearance in daylight is everywhere the signal for violence. The demand for a mate is, in Arendtian terms, the demand for the minimal condition of plurality: not a community, but the irreducible two without which no world can be shared. Antigenesis is accordingly the destruction not of a person but of the possibility of a world.

Arendt identified two faculties that redeem action from its constitutive predicaments. Action is irreversible, and its remedy is forgiveness; action is unpredictable, and its remedy is the promise, which creates islands of predictability in an ocean of uncertainty. *Frankenstein* is the tragedy of the failure of both. Victor promises to make the female, and breaks the promise; the creature's threat — "I shall be with you on your wedding-night" — is a counter-promise, a binding of the future in the mode of vengeance. Neither forgives the other until forgiveness is useless: the creature's plea over Victor's corpse, "what does it avail that I now ask thee to pardon me?" (III.vii; ch. 24), arrives when the only being who could grant it is dead.

7.3

Latour, the Modern Constitution, and the Dialectic of Enlightenment

Bruno Latour's essay "Love Your Monsters" (2011) reads the novel as a parable for the ecological age: Victor's crime was not that he made a creature through hubris but that he abandoned it, and the lesson for technological modernity is not to renounce its creations but to care for them as parents care for children. Latour's earlier *We Have Never Been Modern* (1991) had diagnosed the Modern Constitution as a double operation: a work of purification, which separates nature from society and the human from the non-human, conducted while a work of translation proliferates hybrids that belong wholly to neither. The creature is the quintessential Latourian hybrid — dead and alive, human and animal ("the dissecting room and the slaughter-house furnished many of my materials"), natural and artificial — and Victor's horror is the horror of the

purifier confronting what his own practice has made. *The Modern Prometheus* names the Modern in Latour's sense.

Yet the novel exposes an antinomy that Latour's prescription elides. To care for the creature is to give him a mate; to give him a mate is to make another hybrid and to license hybrids to reproduce without their maker. Care for the made may require more making; the refusal of further making may require the abandonment of the made. The novel does not choose between these horns. It shows that they are horns.

Max Horkheimer and Theodor W. Adorno's *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (1944/1947) supplies the long view. Enlightenment begins, in their account, with Francis Bacon's identification of knowledge and power, and its domination of nature reverts into the domination of human beings and into a new mythology. Waldman's promise that the moderns "penetrate into the recesses of nature, and shew how she works in her hiding places," and Victor's boast that he "pursued nature to her hiding-places," rehearse the Baconian programme, including its figuration of nature as a female to be penetrated — the subject of Carolyn Merchant's influential and contested critique in *The Death of Nature* (1980), against which Peter Pesic (1999) has argued that Bacon's metaphors were less violent than his modern readers allege. The title of one of Bacon's early tracts, *Temporis partus masculus* (c. 1603), "The Masculine Birth of Time," could stand as the motto of Victor's project. The dialectic the Frankfurt theorists describe is the plot of the novel: an enlightenment that sets out to master life ends in a mythic pursuit across the ice, in which the master is bound to the being he made, and the new myth that enlightenment generates is the creature himself.

CHAPTER 8

The Chiasmus of Power

Biopolitics, Bare Life, and the Monstrous Double

8.1

Make Live and Let Die; Make Die and Let Live

In his lectures of 1975–76 ("*Society Must Be Defended*") and in the first volume of *The History of Sexuality* (1976), Michel Foucault located at the end of the eighteenth century a transformation in the nature of power. Sovereign power had been characterized by the right to take life or let live; the new biopower assumes the task to make live and to let die, administering the life of populations through the management of birth, health, and reproduction. Victor Frankenstein is the first biopolitical sovereign in literature in the most literal sense: his power consists in making live, and his crime consists in letting die — in abandoning what he has made to fend for itself. At Orkney his power over reproduction becomes explicit. He decides not only that a being shall live but that a population shall not exist.

The creature answers with the older power. He kills — William, Clerval, Elizabeth, and, through grief, Alphonse Frankenstein — and he lets live. During the Arctic pursuit he keeps his maker alive, leaving him inscriptions on trees and stones and provisions on the trail: "My reign is not yet over … you live, and my power is complete. … You will find near this place, if you follow not too tardily, a dead hare; eat, and be refreshed" (III.vii; ch. 24). The formula of sovereignty is spelled out with juridical exactness: the right of the sovereign is manifested in the power to make die, and its completeness in the decision to let live. The novel stages Foucault's historical transition as a duel and inverts its chronology. The modern power belongs to the maker, the archaic power to the made, so that the creature of modern biopower answers it in the idiom of the sovereignty it displaced.

8.2

Bare Life at the Hearth

Giorgio Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) recovers from archaic Roman law the figure of the man who may be killed with impunity but not sacrificed, and makes this bare life the hidden foundation of sovereign power. The creature is bare life in its purest literary form. When he rescues a girl from drowning, her companion shoots him (II.viii; ch. 16); no law takes notice of the wound. When Victor, after Elizabeth's death, lays his deposition before the magistrate of Geneva, the magistrate receives it with an incredulity that is as much jurisdictional as epistemic: the being described lies beyond the reach of any legal process. The law that cannot reach the creature has already, in the trial of Justine, killed the innocent in his place; and when Victor is arrested in Ireland for the murder of Clerval, the law releases the man who knows himself to be morally responsible. *Frankenstein* is a novel of trials in which the law misfires in every direction, and the reason is structural: the being at the centre of its crimes exists outside the order that would have to judge him. He is neither a person before the law nor a thing beneath it.

8.3

Girard's Monstrous Double

René Girard's *Violence and the Sacred* (1972) describes how mimetic rivalry erodes the differences between antagonists until each perceives the other as a monstrous double, and how communities in crisis restore difference by converging their violence upon a scapegoat, whose expulsion or death refounds order. The novel's final movement is a textbook mimetic crisis. Pursuer and pursued become indistinguishable in their obsessions; Victor confesses that revenge alone keeps him alive, and he vows himself to the destruction of a being whose own existence has become a vow to destroy him; each feeds the other, and each is the other's only interlocutor. Justine is the scapegoat in the strict Girardian sense: an innocent marginal figure — a servant, a woman, a dependant in the household's economy — upon whom the community's violence converges to resolve the crisis precipitated by William's death, and whose execution restores a false peace.

The creature's self-sacrifice, however, exposes the limit of the Girardian mechanism. Sacrifice refounds a community; the creature has none. His immolation on the ice will be witnessed by no one and will found no cult. It is a sacrifice without a congregation, and it therefore does nothing but end. The novel carries the logic of the scapegoat to the point at which, deprived of the plurality it presupposes, it reveals itself as mere destruction.

III

PART THREE

Comparanda

CHAPTER 9
Mythic Comparanda

CHAPTER 10
Gothic and Horror Comparanda

CHAPTER 9

Mythic Comparanda

Narratives of Making

9.1

Pandora and Eve: The Made Woman and the Companion Granted

Two mythic traditions furnish the archetype of the made woman, and the novel engages both. In Hesiod, Pandora is fashioned at Zeus's command by Hephaestus from earth and water, dressed by Athena, adorned by the Graces and Persuasion, and given by Hermes a shameless mind and a thievish nature (*Works and Days* 59–82); she is then presented as a gift to Epimetheus. In Genesis the Lord observes that "it is not good that the man should be alone; I will make him an help meet for him" (2:18), and forms the woman from Adam's rib. In the eighth book of *Paradise Lost* Milton converts the episode into a philosophical dialogue in which Adam argues for a companion and God, having tested him, grants his request.

The novel contains two Pandoras. The first is Elizabeth, who in the 1831 text is introduced into the Frankenstein household by Victor's mother with the words "I have a pretty present for my Victor—to-morrow he shall have it," and whom the child accordingly regards "as mine—mine to protect, love, and cherish" (ch. 1). She is the gift-woman of the Hesiodic economy, presented to the son by the mother and destined by the dying mother's wish to be his bride. The second is the female creature, the withheld Pandora, the counter-gift the creature demands and his maker refuses. The fates of the two converge: the one is destroyed on Orkney, the other at Evian. Gayle Rubin's analysis of "the traffic in women" (1975), developed from Claude Lévi-Strauss's account of the exchange of women as the foundation of kinship (1949), illuminates the convergence. Both women are objects of transactions between men — the one bequeathed, the other contracted — and the creature's murder of Elizabeth is a reciprocal transaction: the payment of a woman for a woman.

The Miltonic parallel is more exact still. Adam's argument in Book VIII is an argument from solitude and from equality: "In solitude / What happiness, who can enjoy alone, / Or all enjoying, what contentment find?" (VIII.364–366); "Among

unequals what societie / Can sort, what harmonie or true delight?" (VIII.383–384). God replies by pointing to his own eternal solitude, then concedes that he spoke "to try thee" (VIII.437), and promises "Thy likeness, thy fit help, thy other self, / Thy wish, exactly to thy hearts desire" (VIII.450–451). The creature's speech on the Mer de Glace reproduces Adam's argument point for point, including its criterion of equality: "one as deformed and horrible as myself would not deny herself to me. My companion must be of the same species, and have the same defects" (II.ix; ch. 17). The creature has learned his theology of companionship from Milton. What he has not learned, because Milton could not teach it, is that his maker would administer the test and then fail it himself. Gilbert and Gubar's insight that the creature is in many respects Eve rather than Adam — the secondary, defective, excluded creation — is confirmed by the fact that he must ask for what Adam was granted.

9.2

Asclepius and Pygmalion: Thunderbolt and Kiss

Asclepius, son of Apollo, was so skilled in medicine that he raised the dead. Pindar (*Pythian* 3.54–58) tells that he was bribed with gold to bring a man back from death, and that Zeus struck both healer and healed with the thunderbolt; later mythographers name Hippolytus among those he restored. In the myth the lightning is the instrument by which the sovereign god punishes transgression of the boundary between life and death. In *Frankenstein* the lightning has become the means of transgression: the "spark of being" that Victor infuses into the lifeless body is the thunderbolt domesticated, and the blasted oak of Victor's youth marks the moment at which the punitive fire became an object of research. Modernity converts the divine sanction into a technical resource; the novel shows that the sanction returns, displaced, as the catastrophe the technique produces.

Ovid's Pygmalion (*Metamorphoses* X.243–297) carves an ivory maiden, falls in love with her, and prays to Venus, who animates her beneath his kiss. Love is the cause of animation. Victor animates without love and recoils at the moment of animation; the novel is an anti-Pygmalion. Rousseau's *Pygmalion*, a *scène lyrique* (written 1762, performed 1770), adds a detail that throws the creature's condition into relief. Rousseau's Galathée, coming to life, touches herself and says "Moi"; touches the marble and says "Ce n'est plus moi"; touches Pygmalion and says "Ah! encore moi." The made woman's first act is to recognize her maker as herself, and the maker's ecstasy consists in being so recognized. The creature's first acts are the reverse: he reaches for his maker and is refused, and his self-recognition at the pool is the recognition of a self that no one will acknowledge as continuous with theirs.

9.3

The Golem and the Word

The Babylonian Talmud records that the sage Rava created a man and sent him to Rabbi Zeira, who spoke to him and received no answer, and said: you are from the magicians; return to your dust (*Sanhedrin* 65b). The same tractate describes Adam, in the second hour of the first day, as a *golem*, an unformed mass (*Sanhedrin* 38b). The golem legend, elaborated in medieval mystical commentary on the *Sefer Yetzirah* and crystallized in the nineteenth-century Prague tradition attributed to Rabbi Judah Loew, makes the artificial man a being animated by the divine Name or by the word *emet* (truth) inscribed on his brow, and deactivated by the erasure of its first letter, which leaves *met* (dead). Gershom Scholem's essay on the idea of the golem (1953) emphasizes that the golem cannot speak, because the human creator cannot confer the highest soul; in 1965 Scholem named the first computer of the Weizmann Institute "Golem Aleph."

The comparison isolates the decisive innovation of Mary Shelley's novel. The golem tradition withholds from the made being precisely the capacity for speech; the creature is the most eloquent figure in his book. By granting the made being language, Mary Shelley transfers the scene of moral judgment from the creator's power to the creature's argument. The deactivation of the golem by the erasure of a letter offers a further analogy. Antigenesis in the Jewish tradition is a textual act, the removal of a sign; in *Frankenstein* it is a carnal act, the tearing of flesh, and the final antigenesis is the creature's immolation of his own body so that it may "afford no light" to any future maker.

9.4

Job on the Ice; Cain, Ahasuerus, and the Mariner

The Book of Job supplies the novel with the structure of its central confrontation. Job curses the day of his birth ("Let the day perish wherein I was born," 3:3) and demands that his maker answer for his suffering; the Lord answers out of the whirlwind (38–41) with a catalogue of the sublime creatures of his making, Behemoth and Leviathan, and does not justify himself. The creature's curse — "Cursed, cursed creator! Why did I live?" (II.viii; ch. 16) — is Job's, and his demand for an accounting is Job's. But the topography of the Mer de Glace inverts the roles. The creature descends from the sublime, "advancing towards me with superhuman speed" over the ice, and speaks from the place of the whirlwind; his maker, who came to the glacier seeking sublimity, must listen. The creature occupies at once the position of the complaining creature

and of the voice from the sublime. And the maker has nothing to say from the whirlwind, because, unlike Job's God, he has no answer to give.

Other figures of the cursed wanderer accumulate around both protagonists. Cain, the first murderer, marked and condemned to wander (Genesis 4), hovers over Victor's self-accusation — "I, not in deed, but in effect, was the true murderer" (I.vii; ch. 8) — and over the creature's exile. The Wandering Jew, who appears in Lewis's *The Monk* and in Percy Shelley's juvenilia, haunts the final pursuit. Above all, Coleridge's *Rime of the Ancient Mariner* (1798) structures the frame. Walton promises that he will "kill no albatross" (Letter 2); Victor, fleeing the newly animated creature, quotes the stanza of the man who walks a lonesome road knowing that "a frightful fiend / Doth close behind him tread" (I.iv; ch. 5); and Victor's compulsive narration to Walton repeats the Mariner's compulsion to tell. The Mariner detains a guest from a wedding, and Mary Lowe-Evans (1993) has read Walton as Mary Shelley's wedding guest. Within the novel the Mariner's curse is fulfilled at a wedding — Victor's — that never achieves consummation.

CHAPTER 10

Gothic and Horror Comparanda

From Otranto to R.U.R.

10.1

From Otranto to Diodati

The English Gothic was born of a theogonic anxiety. Horace Walpole's *The Castle of Otranto* (1764) opens with the death of the heir Conrad, crushed on his wedding day by a gigantic helmet that falls from the sky, and its plot is driven by the usurper Manfred's determination to secure a male succession by divorcing his wife and marrying his dead son's betrothed. The first Gothic novel is a novel about a father's attempt to control reproduction in order to forestall the prophesied loss of his line, and the sublime fragment of an outsized body — the helmet, the gigantic limbs glimpsed in the castle — is its sign. *Frankenstein* recomposes this matrix: a dynastic father, a destroyed heir, a wedding turned to death, and a gigantic body whose parts exceed every proportion.

Ann Radcliffe's *The Mysteries of Udolpho* (1794) contains the most famous artificial corpse of the Gothic before Mary Shelley's: behind a black veil Emily discovers what she takes to be a decaying human body, explained at last as a wax memento mori. Radcliffe's supernatural is always explained; Mary Shelley refuses the explanation, and her corpse truly moves. Matthew Lewis's *The Monk* (1796) supplies the demonic made image: Ambrosio's devotion to a painting of the Madonna becomes the channel through which Matilda — revealed at last as an agent of hell — engineers his fall, and the monk's Faustian compact ends in a protracted death on the rocks. William Beckford's *Vathek* (1786) closes in the Hall of Eblis, where those who sought forbidden knowledge wander with hearts perpetually burning, an image of endlessly renewed torment that the creature's grief recalls.

The Diodati circle read *Fantasmagoriana* (1812), Jean-Baptiste Benoît Eyriès's French translation of German ghost stories, before Byron proposed the contest. Of its products, John William Polidori's *The Vampyre* (1819) inaugurated the aristocratic predator of modern horror; Byron's "Darkness" (1816) imagined the extinction of the

race in a sunless world; his *Manfred* (1817) staged a Faustian magus who refuses submission to spirits. Mary Shelley's contribution is the only one to make the monster a speaking subject whose perspective structures the center of the text.

10.2

Hoffmann's Olimpia and Villiers's Hadaly

E. T. A. Hoffmann's "Der Sandmann," published in his *Nachtstücke* (1816), was composed within months of *Frankenstein*'s conception, and it contains the period's other great artificial woman. The automaton Olimpia is constructed by the professor Spalanzani, whose name recalls the physiologist Lazzaro Spallanzani, celebrated for the first artificial insemination of a mammal and for his experiments reviving desiccated rotifers — the very phenomena of suspended animation that Mary Shelley remembered as Darwin's "vermicelli." The student Nathanael falls in love with Olimpia, whose conversation consists of the single sigh "Ach, ach!"; he discovers her nature when her makers struggle over her body and her eyes are wrenched from her head, and he is driven to madness and death. Ernst Jentsch (1906) located the uncanny in intellectual uncertainty whether a thing is animate; Freud's "The Uncanny" (1919) relocated it to the return of the repressed. Both readings illuminate *Frankenstein*: Jentsch's describes the creature's ontological undecidability, Freud's the cultural return of the unmade bride (Chapter 15).

Olimpia is the completed bride — the made woman perfectly compliant, a mirror for her lover's narcissism. Her horror is her emptiness. The female creature, by contrast, horrifies her maker by her potential fullness: that she will think, reason, and refuse. The two texts of 1816 thus divide between them the two fates of the made woman, and those fates meet again in Villiers de l'Isle-Adam's *L'Ève future* (1886), in which a fictionalized Edison constructs the android Hadaly for Lord Ewald, whose fiancée's beauty is matched by the vulgarity of her mind. Hadaly is lost when the ship carrying her to England burns and sinks. Like the remains of Victor's female, the completed made woman goes to the bottom of the sea. The sea is the archive of unmade brides.

10.3

Poe, Stevenson, Wells

Edgar Allan Poe's "Ligeia" (1838) narrates the resurrection of a dead first wife in the corpse of the second: a bride is made from the dead, and the narrator's horror is the recognition of the beloved in the reanimated body. "The Facts in the Case of M. Valdemar" (1845) suspends a dying man's death by mesmerism for seven months; when

released, he collapses into "a nearly liquid mass of loathsome—of detestable putridity." Poe exposes the abject truth that the creature's animation conceals: the reanimated body is a corpse whose dissolution has been deferred.

Robert Louis Stevenson's *Strange Case of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde* (1886) internalizes the relation of maker and made. Hyde's deformity is indefinable — "He must be deformed somewhere; he gives a strong feeling of deformity, although I couldn't specify the point" — and the failure of the physiognomic gaze to specify what it perceives repeats the creature's predicament. The two bodies that Mary Shelley kept apart are fused in one, and the pursuit across the ice becomes the alternation of identities within a single house.

H. G. Wells's *The Island of Doctor Moreau* (1896) is the novel's dialectical pendant. Moreau vivisects animals into humanoid Beast Folk and, unlike Victor, does not abandon them. He remains, and he governs: he gives them a Law — "Not to go on all-Fours; that is the Law. Are we not Men?" — and enforces it with the terror of the House of Pain. Abandonment is replaced by domination; the result is equally catastrophic, and after Moreau's death the Beast Folk revert. Read together, the two novels exhaust the alternatives available to a maker who lacks the political art: to flee or to rule. What neither possesses is what Plato's Hermes distributed to all alike.

10.4

Stoker, Lovecraft, Čapek

Bram Stoker's *Dracula* (1897) realizes the fear Victor articulated on Orkney. Jonathan Harker imagines the Count transferred to London, "where, perhaps, for centuries to come he might, amongst its teeming millions, satiate his lust for blood, and create a new and ever widening circle of semi-demons to batten on the helpless." Here is the race of devils propagated upon the earth, reproducing not sexually but by contagion, and threatening the species not through scarcity but through proliferation. Franco Moretti's reading of Dracula as monopoly capital and of the creature as proletariat (1983) is complemented by a demographic reading: both novels are fantasies about the reproduction of a population that would supplant humankind.

H. P. Lovecraft's "Herbert West—Reanimator" (1922) reduces reanimation to serial technique: West's reagent must be applied to ever fresher corpses, and the results are mute, violent, and indistinguishable. The loss of the creature's voice in twentieth-century horror — anticipated by the mute creature of Richard Brinsley Peake's *Presumption* (1823) and canonized by James Whale's film of 1931 — is the measure of what mass culture could not tolerate in Mary Shelley's conception: a made being who argues.

Karel Čapek's *R.U.R.* (1920) is the counterfactual completion of the Orkney scene. Old Rossum, a physiologist, sought to manufacture life in order to prove God superfluous; his nephew rationalized the process into industrial production. As the robots multiply, human births cease. Helena Glory burns the manuscript containing the formula for robot manufacture — an antigenesis performed by a woman — but the robots revolt and exterminate humankind, all except the builder Alquist, who cannot reconstruct the formula. In the epilogue two robots, Primus and Helena, discover love, and Alquist sends them forth as a new Adam and Eve. Čapek stages exactly what Victor's veto was meant to forestall: the made pair becomes the progenitor of a successor kind, and the theogony that *Frankenstein* aborted is completed.

IV

PART FOUR

Antigenesis

CHAPTER 11
The Orkney Laboratory

CHAPTER 12
The Theogonic Unconscious

CHAPTER 13
The Promethean Chiasmus

CHAPTER 14
Three Refusals and the Promethean Remainder

CHAPTER 15
The Pandoric Return

CHAPTER 11

The Orkney Laboratory

A Close Reading of the Unmaking

11.1

The Edge of the World

The second laboratory inverts the first. The first was "a solitary chamber, or rather cell, at the top of the house" (I.iii; ch. 4) in a university town at the center of European learning; the second is a hut on an island "hardly more than a rock," whose barren soil affords pasture for "a few miserable cows" and oatmeal for its five inhabitants (III.ii; ch. 19). The first creation was performed in an "enthusiastic frenzy" that "blinded me to the horror of my employment"; the second proceeds in revulsion — "now I went to it in cold blood, and my heart often sickened at the work of my hands." The first produced a being whose features were described in clinical detail; the second produces a being of whom the text records nothing — no feature, no proportion, no colour, no face. The female creature is the only figure in the novel who is wholly unrepresented. She is pure potentiality, and the destruction that befalls her is the destruction of a possibility rather than of a person: the most radical object an act of refusal can have.

The scene of the unmaking is constructed with dramatic precision. Victor sits in his laboratory as the moon rises; his mind turns to the effects of his work; he reasons; and at the conclusion of his reasoning he looks up to see "the dæmon at the casement," "a ghastly grin" wrinkling his lips (III.iii; ch. 20). Only then does he destroy the body. The sequence matters. The decision is reached by argument, but it is executed under the gaze of the being whose future it forecloses. Antigenesis is not a private act of conscience; it is performed before the claimant, as a reply to him.

11.2

The Deliberation

The passage in which Victor deliberates is the most philosophically dense in the novel and must be read whole:

> I was now about to form another being, of whose dispositions I was alike ignorant; she might become ten thousand times more malignant than her mate, and delight, for its own sake, in murder and wretchedness. He had sworn to quit the neighbourhood of man, and hide himself in deserts; but she had not; and she, who in all probability was to become a thinking and reasoning animal, might refuse to comply with a compact made before her creation. They might even hate each other; the creature who already lived loathed his own deformity, and might he not conceive a greater abhorrence for it when it came before his eyes in the female form? She also might turn with disgust from him to the superior beauty of man; she might quit him, and he be again alone, exasperated by the fresh provocation of being deserted by one of his own species. Even if they were to leave Europe, and inhabit the deserts of the new world, yet one of the first results of those sympathies for which the dæmon thirsted would be children, and a race of devils would be propagated upon the earth, who might make the very existence of the species of man a condition precarious and full of terror. Had I a right, for my own benefit, to inflict this curse upon everlasting generations? (III.iii; ch. 20)

The reasons resolve into three clusters. The first concerns *autonomy*: the female's dispositions are unknown; she is not bound by her mate's oath; she will reason, and may refuse the compact; she may exercise sexual choice and prefer "the superior beauty of man." The second concerns *propagation*: the sympathies the creature seeks will issue in children. The third concerns *succession*: the offspring will constitute a race that may render the existence of the human species precarious. The question that closes the passage — whether Victor has a right to inflict this curse upon "everlasting generations" — reframes the whole as a problem of intergenerational justice, and the sentence that follows completes the frame: "I shuddered to think that future ages might curse me as their pest, whose selfishness had not hesitated to buy its own peace at the price, perhaps, of the existence of the whole human race." Each cluster corresponds to a body of thought examined in Part One.

11.3

“A Compact Made Before Her Creation”: Sophie, Wollstonecraft, and the Sexual Contract

Anne K. Mellor (1988) rightly identified in this passage Victor’s terror of an independent female will and of female sexual choice. What has not been registered is the scene’s precise genealogy and its juridical form. In the fifth book of *Émile*, Rousseau, having formed his ideal man, proceeds to design his wife. Sophie is made for Émile: her education, her tastes, her accomplishments, and her desires are determined by the requirement that she complete him. Wollstonecraft’s *Vindication* answered that such a being, if rational, cannot be bound by a design to which she did not consent, and that the attempt to form her for another’s use deforms her. The agreement reached on the Mer de Glace is a Rousseauian design executed as a contract. Two male parties, creator and creature, agree upon the production of a female whose nature, residence, and sexual destiny are fixed in advance: she will be “of the same species,” she will have “the same defects,” she will accompany her mate to “the vast wilds of South America” and quit the neighbourhood of man. Victor’s fear is the Wollstonecraftian conclusion: that she will be a rational creature, and therefore not bound.

Carole Pateman’s *The Sexual Contract* (1988) supplies the political theory that makes the scene legible. The social contract of the classical theorists, Pateman argued, presupposes an earlier, repressed sexual contract among men establishing their orderly access to women; the story of the original pact is a story of fraternal agreement over female bodies. The compact on the Mer de Glace is a sexual contract in its purest form: a covenant between males concerning the body of a female who does not exist when it is concluded. What Victor confronts on Orkney is the crisis of the sexual contract — the recognition that the contracted woman would be a party, and that a party may refuse. The novel’s most radical sentence is uttered by its least radical character: the maker fears that the woman he makes will be free.

The fear has a domestic counterpart. Elizabeth, too, is bound by a compact made by others. The dying Caroline declares that her “firmest hopes of future happiness were placed on the prospect of your union” (I.ii; ch. 3), and the marriage is thereafter treated as a family obligation. In the letter she writes to Victor on his return from Ireland, Elizabeth reflects on that compact with a reasoning woman’s scruple, asks whether he loves another, and offers to release him from it (III.v; ch. 22). She is a thinking and reasoning being who considers the compact and chooses to comply, and she dies on her wedding night. The female creature is the limit-case of Elizabeth’s condition: the woman made for a compact, destroyed lest she refuse it. Milton’s

formula for the relation of the sexes — "Hee for God only, shee for God in him" (*Paradise Lost* IV.299) — is the theology of which Victor's fear is the secular crisis.

11.4

"A Race of Devils": Malthus, Succession, Darwin

The second and third clusters of reasons acquire their full significance when set beside Victor's original ambition. At Ingolstadt he dreamed: "A new species would bless me as its creator and source; many happy and excellent natures would owe their being to me. No father could claim the gratitude of his child so completely as I should deserve theirs" (I.iii; ch. 4). On Orkney he fears that "a race of devils would be propagated upon the earth." The object of the dream and the object of the fear are the same: a new, reproducing kind. What distinguishes blessing from curse is not the existence of the species but the mode of its reproduction. The species of the dream issues from the father alone and owes him gratitude; the species of the fear issues from a female and owes him nothing. Antigenesis is therefore not a renunciation of Victor's Promethean ambition but its patriarchal completion: the veto on any reproduction that would escape the father's authorship.

The terms in which the veto is reasoned are Malthusian. Victor's argument concerns the propagation of a population and the precarity of an existing species; it imagines the multiplication of offspring as a threat to those already seated at nature's feast. The creature had anticipated precisely this objection and answered it in the idiom of Godwinian benevolence and Shelleyan vegetarianism: "My food is not that of man; I do not destroy the lamb and the kid to glut my appetite; acorns and berries afford me sufficient nourishment. … We shall make our bed of dried leaves; the sun will shine on us as on man, and will ripen our food" (II.ix; ch. 17). The pair will not compete with humans for subsistence; they will inhabit the uninhabited. The confrontation between the Mer de Glace and Orkney is thus a confrontation between Godwin and Malthus: between the doctrine that benevolence will flourish where circumstances permit and the doctrine that reproduction must be checked because it outruns the means of life. Mary Shelley, Godwin's daughter and Percy Shelley's wife, gives the Malthusian argument to the destroyer.

Yet the novel does not simply refute Malthus. It grants Victor's fear a dignity the household's polemic denied it, because it extends the Malthusian logic from scarcity to succession. Victor fears not merely that the new race will consume humanity's food but that it will render humanity's existence "precarious and full of terror." This is the logic of interspecific competition that Darwin, reading Malthus in 1838, would generalize as "the doctrine of Malthus applied with manifold force to the whole animal and vegetable kingdoms" (*On the Origin of Species*, ch. 3). Victor's deliberation is the

first species-level calculation of existential risk in modern literature. Samuel Butler's "Darwin among the Machines" (1863), and the "Book of the Machines" in *Erewhon* (1872), in which a society destroys every machine invented in the preceding centuries to forestall their evolution into humanity's successors, institutionalize the antigenetic reasoning that Victor performs alone.

11.5

Burial at Sea and the Substituted Corpse

The aftermath of the unmaking is narrated in the vocabulary of murder. "The remains of the half-finished creature, whom I had destroyed, lay scattered on the floor, and I almost felt as if I had mangled the living flesh of a human being" (III.iv; ch. 21). He gathers the remains into a basket weighted with stones and rows out by night; he "felt as if I was about to commit a dreadful crime, and avoided with shuddering anxiety any encounter with my fellow-creatures." He casts the basket into the sea and listens "to the gurgling sound as it sank." The disposal of the female is a disposal of evidence, and Victor experiences it as the concealment of a homicide.

The sea then returns a body. Victor falls asleep in his boat, drifts to the Irish coast, and is arrested for the murder of a man whose corpse was found on the shore that night. The corpse is Clerval's. The structure is a substitution: the unmade female is answered within hours by a dead male friend, and within months by a dead bride. Antigenesis does not subtract a being from the world; it displaces a death onto those nearest the one who refuses. Goethe's ballad "Der Zauberlehrling" (1797) had furnished the parable: the apprentice who cannot halt the broom he has animated splits it with an axe, and the two halves rise as two servants. The attempt to unmake multiplies what it sought to end. "Die ich rief, die Geister, / Werd' ich nun nicht los" — the spirits I summoned I now cannot be rid of.

CHAPTER 12

The Theogonic Unconscious

12.1

Succession and Swallowing

Hesiod's *Theogony* is a history of fathers attempting to prevent their own supersession. Ouranos, hating his children, hides them in the body of Gaia as each is born (156–160); Kronos, warned that he will be overthrown by a son, swallows each of his children at birth (459–467); Zeus, warned that Metis, his first wife and "wisest among gods and mortal men," will bear first a daughter and then "a son of overbearing spirit, king of gods and men," deceives her with cunning words and puts her in his own belly while she is pregnant (886–900), and himself gives birth to Athena from his head (924–926). With this last act the succession myth ends. Zeus, having incorporated the cunning intelligence (*mētis*) of the female and appropriated her reproductive power, secures an order that will not be overthrown. Marcel Detienne and Jean-Pierre Vernant (1974) have shown how fundamental the appropriation of *mētis* — the oblique, adaptive, transformative intelligence associated in Greek thought with women, craftsmen, and the sea — is to the Olympian settlement.

The thesis of this chapter is that Victor Frankenstein reenacts Zeus's double act, and that the subtitle, which casts him as Prometheus, conceals the novel's true mythic grammar. Like Zeus, Victor gives birth without a woman: the creature issues, as Athena from Zeus's skull, from the father's intellect, and the alchemical and Baconian fantasy of a masculine birth is its precondition. Like Zeus, Victor confronts a female whose intelligence threatens his authority — "a thinking and reasoning animal" — and whose offspring would supplant his kind; and like Zeus, he forecloses that succession by an act of incorporation and concealment. The remains of the female are not swallowed by her maker but by the sea, into which they sink with a "gurgling sound": the swallowing is displaced from the paternal belly to the maternal element. And Aeschylus' Prometheus, who holds the secret of the marriage that must not be consummated lest it produce a son greater than his father, is the mythic precedent for the knowledge that drives the Orkney decision.

But the modern theogony fails where the ancient succeeded. Zeus's swallowing of Metis founds a cosmos; Victor's destruction of the female founds nothing. It does not secure an order; it initiates an extinction. *Frankenstein* is an inverted theogony: a narrative of the birth of a new kind that ends not in the establishment of a sovereign order but in the mutual sterilization of the generations.

12.2

The Wedding Night: Mutual Sterilization

The creature's reply to the destruction of his mate is an exact reciprocity: "It is well. I go; but remember, I shall be with you on your wedding-night" (III.iii; ch. 20). Victor misreads the threat with a consistency that is itself revealing. He assumes that the creature intends to kill *him*, and on the night of his marriage he patrols the inn at Evian with pistols while his bride waits alone. He cannot conceive that the logic of the threat is the logic of the injury: a bride for a bride. His narcissism is precisely the incapacity to imagine that the being he made might reason by analogy, as he himself reasons, about the meaning of a mate.

Elizabeth is strangled on the wedding night, before the marriage is consummated. Victor's father dies of grief within days. Victor will not marry again, and the creature will never mate. The novel ends with both lines sterilized by the action of the other: the creature has prevented the creator's reproduction as the creator prevented his. (Victor's younger brother Ernest survives, a narratively inert remainder whose fate the novel does not pursue.) The dream that followed the creation had already fused bride and grave: Victor embraced Elizabeth, and as he kissed her she became the corpse of his mother, "and I saw the grave-worms crawling in the folds of the flannel" (I.iv; ch. 5). The wedding night executes the dream. The Promethean act that sought to abolish death by producing life outside sexuality ends by making sexuality itself the site of death.

12.3

Totem and Taboo without Brothers

Freud's *Totem and Taboo* (1913) proposed a mythic origin for law and religion. In the primal horde a violent father monopolized the women; the excluded sons banded together, killed and devoured him, and, overcome by remorse, instituted the prohibitions he had embodied — against killing the totem and against possessing the women of the clan — in a "deferred obedience" that is the foundation of morality and social order. *Frankenstein* is *Totem and Taboo* without the band of brothers. The father denies the son any woman; the son, alone, kills the father's woman; the father

dies in pursuit of the son; and the son, standing over the father's corpse, is overcome by remorse: "Oh, Frankenstein! generous and self-devoted being! what does it avail that I now ask thee to pardon me? I, who irretrievably destroyed thee by destroying all thou lovedst" (III.vii; ch. 24).

Everything in Freud's myth is present except the plurality that converts crime into law. The brothers of the primal horde found culture because they are many, and because their guilt must be shared and regulated; the creature's guilt has no one to share it, and his remorse issues not in a totem meal but in a pyre. The novel thereby demonstrates, by subtraction, a proposition that neither Freud nor Arendt stated in these terms: that the origin of law in guilt requires plurality, and that the singular being, whatever his crime and whatever his remorse, can found nothing. Antigenesis, by denying the creature a kind, denied him the possibility of becoming the origin of a law.

12.4

Theogony without Gaia

In Hesiod the fathers' antigenetic violence is resisted by mothers. Gaia conspires with Kronos against Ouranos and furnishes the sickle; Rhea conceals the infant Zeus and gives Kronos a stone wrapped in swaddling clothes. The succession myth is a contest in which maternal cunning protects the child against paternal fear. *Frankenstein* is a theogony without Gaia. Its mothers are uniformly dead or estranged: Caroline Beaufort, who dies of the scarlet fever she contracted nursing Elizabeth; Elizabeth's own mother, who in the 1831 text dies giving birth to her; Safie's Christian Arab mother, dead before the narrative begins, whose teaching of "an independence of spirit" survives only in her daughter's flight; Justine's mother, who cannot endure her. Nature, the remaining maternal figure, is the mother whose "hiding-places" Victor penetrates. No one conceals the creature from his father's fear, and no one substitutes a stone. Margaret Homans's reading of the novel as a "circumvention of the maternal" (1986) is confirmed at the level of mythic structure: the creature is exposed because the figure who, in every ancient version, would have protected him is missing.

The one maternal presence that persists is formal. The entire novel is addressed by Robert Walton to his sister, Margaret Walton Saville, whose initials — M. W. S. — are those of the author. She never replies. The silent maternal addressee who receives the whole tale is the absent Gaia of this theogony, and she is also, as the Conclusion will argue, its author.

CHAPTER 13

The Promethean Chiasmus

13.1

The Crossing of Roles

A chiasmus is a figure in which terms are repeated in reverse order, so that their relation crosses: A B / B A. The novel's two protagonists begin and end in crossed positions across every register in which their relation is articulated, and the point at which their trajectories intersect is the Orkney laboratory. Table 1 maps the crossing.

TABLE 1 *The Promethean chiasmus across six registers*

REGISTER	VICTOR AT THE OUTSET	VICTOR AT THE CLOSE	THE CREATURE AT THE OUTSET	THE CREATURE AT THE CLOSE
Hesiodic–Aeschylean	Prometheus, maker of man and thief of fire	Zeus who swallows Metis; Epimetheus of afterthought	The clay figure, Ovid's moulded man	Prometheus: fire-bringer, chained, perpetually consumed
Miltonic	God the Maker	The archangel "chained in an eternal hell"	Adam, who asks for a companion	The fallen angel, then the penitent who asks pardon
Hegelian	Lord	Bondsman: "I am your master;—obey!"	Bondsman	Lord
Foucauldian	Biopower: makes live, lets die	Subject of sovereign power, kept alive to suffer	Abandoned life	Sovereign: makes die, lets live
Theogonic	Father securing his succession	Heirless; line ended on the wedding night	Son without a mother	Son without a bride; self-immolated
Narratological	Narrator of the creature's origin	Narrated by Walton, then silenced by death	Object of description	Central narrator and last speaker

Victor himself registers the Miltonic crossing. Having begun as the creator who promised himself a species' gratitude, he ends by describing himself to Walton in the terms of the Satan of *Paradise Lost*: "like the archangel who aspired to omnipotence, I am chained in an eternal hell" (III.vii; ch. 24). The verb is Promethean as well as Satanic; the maker ends bound. The creature, who began by claiming Adam's place and then confessed himself "rather the fallen angel," ends in a posture of contrition foreign to Milton's Satan and proper to the penitent Adam of the last books. The name of the maker condenses the irony. In *Paradise Lost* Satan's epithet for God is "the Potent Victor" (I.95); the creature's maker bears Satan's name for God, and ends as Satan.

13.2

The Catastrophe of Forethought

The Titans' names supply the chiasmus with its epistemological dimension. Victor's knowledge is Epimethean throughout: he understands what he has done only when it is done, and his narrative is a long confession of afterthought. The single moment at which he exercises genuinely Promethean forethought — when he projects the consequences of his act across "everlasting generations" — is the moment that precipitates the catastrophe. His foresight is scaled to the species and blind to the proximate: he forecasts the precarity of humankind in future ages and fails to foresee, despite an explicit warning, the death of the woman who will lie beside him within the year. The creature, by contrast, is a true Promethean intelligence. He plans, he forecasts, he announces his intentions and executes them to the letter.

The point bears on the theory of precaution. The novel does not say that forethought fails. It says that forethought exercised at the scale of aggregates can coexist with, and even produce, blindness at the scale of persons, and that a precautionary decision taken in the name of everlasting generations displaces its costs onto those nearest to hand. The Aeschylean Prometheus gave mortals blind hopes to keep them from foreseeing their doom; the modern Prometheus has foresight without sight.

13.3

The Creature as Fire-Bringer

The creature's history is a history of fire. His first technical discovery is fire, found in embers "left by some wandering beggars"; he thrusts his hand into it in joy and withdraws it with a cry of pain, and his first philosophical reflection concerns the

duality of the Promethean gift: “How strange, I thought, that the same cause should produce such opposite effects!” (II.iii; ch. 11). He learns to preserve fire, to feed it, and to cook with it. His first social acts are gifts of fuel: by night he gathers firewood for the impoverished cottagers and clears the snow from their path, and he hears them speak of their unseen benefactor as a “good spirit” (II.iv; ch. 12). After his rejection he burns their abandoned cottage, the gift of fire turned to vengeance. At the end he promises to “ascend my funeral pile triumphantly, and exult in the agony of the torturing flames” (III.vii; ch. 24).

Marcel Mauss’s *Essai sur le don* (1925) established that gifts generate obligations to receive and to reciprocate; his short essay “Gift, gift” (1924) observed that the German word for gift means poison. Jacques Derrida’s *Given Time* (1991) argued that a gift recognized as a gift is annulled by the debt it creates, so that the gift must not appear as gift. The creature’s gifts satisfy Derrida’s condition to the letter: they are possible only so long as the giver is invisible. The moment he appears, the gift economy collapses into violence. Prometheus too gave in secret, by theft, and was punished when the gift was discovered.

The Promethean punishment migrates with the Promethean gift. Prometheus is bound to a rock where his liver, devoured by day, regrows by night; the creature is bound to a solitude that no act can loosen, and his grief is renewed each time it is consumed. Byron’s line — “Thy Godlike crime was to be kind” — fits the creature and not his maker. Goethe’s Prometheus forms a race “to suffer, to weep”; the creature is the one of that race who suffers and weeps. Percy Shelley’s Prometheus is liberated by revoking his curse; the creature, alone among the novel’s characters, revokes his, standing over the corpse of the man he cursed. The referent of the subtitle has migrated. The Modern Prometheus is the creature.

CHAPTER 14

Three Refusals and the Promethean Remainder

The novel's final movement can be read as a sequence of experiments in the limitation of Promethean power. Three modalities of refusal are staged — the sovereign, the democratic, and the sacrificial — and each is tested against what I call the Promethean remainder.

14.1

Sovereign Refusal: The Veto

Victor's refusal on Orkney has four defining features. It is *unilateral*: decided by one person on behalf of the species. It is *secret*: performed at night, in a remote place, and concealed. It is *posterior*: exercised after an original creation whose consequences it seeks to contain. And it is *exclusive*: taken without the participation of the being most affected by it, who learns of it by watching through a window. The novel shows that a refusal with these four features converts a claimant into an enemy and displaces its costs onto the proximate.

Victor's last act of sovereign refusal extends the veto from bodies to knowledge. When Walton asks how the creature was made, Victor will not tell him: "Are you mad, my friend? … Would you also create for yourself and the world a demoniacal enemy?" (III.vii; ch. 24). The Aeschylean Prometheus withheld a secret from the tyrant; Victor withholds a secret from the next Prometheus. Sovereign refusal ends in epistemic withholding.

14.2

Democratic Refusal: Walton's Crew and Dante's Ulysses

Walton's ship, trapped in the ice, is visited by a deputation of sailors who demand that, if the ice releases them, he steer south. Victor, dying, rises to address them: "Did you not call this a glorious expedition? … You were hereafter to be hailed as the benefactors of your species. … Do not return to your families with the stigma of

disgrace marked on your brows" (III.vii; ch. 24). The speech recomposes the most famous oration in the literature of transgressive exploration. In the twenty-sixth canto of Dante's *Inferno*, Ulysses persuades his aged crew to sail beyond the Pillars of Hercules into the unpeopled world with a brief oration: "Considerate la vostra semenza: / fatti non foste a viver come bruti, / ma per seguir virtute e canoscenza" — consider your origin; you were not made to live as brutes, but to pursue virtue and knowledge (XXVI.118–120). Dante's crew is persuaded and perishes within sight of the mountain of Purgatory. Walton's crew is not persuaded, and lives. Walton consents to return: "The die is cast; I have consented to return, if we are not destroyed. Thus are my hopes blasted by cowardice and indecision; I come back ignorant and disappointed."

The democratic veto is the only refusal in the novel that succeeds in saving lives. It is collective, open, prospective, and exercised by those whose lives the quest endangers. Its price is the Promethean leader's sense of disgrace, and the novel records that price without endorsing the leader's estimate of it. Tennyson's "Ulysses" (1842), resolved "To strive, to seek, to find, and not to yield," would reassert the Dantean ethos for the Victorian imperial age; *Frankenstein* had already given the crew the last word.

14.3

Sacrificial Refusal: The Pyre

The creature's refusal is directed at himself. "I shall collect my funeral pile, and consume to ashes this miserable frame, that its remains may afford no light to any curious and unhallowed wretch, who would create such another as I have been" (III.vii; ch. 24). He internalizes Victor's veto and executes it upon the only body still available to it: his own. He destroys not only himself but the evidence of his making, the last material record from which the procedure might be reconstructed. It is the most complete antigenesis in the novel, and the only voluntary one. Yet the narrative withholds it. The creature springs from the cabin window onto an ice-raft and is "soon borne away by the waves, and lost in darkness and distance." The pyre is promised, not narrated. The novel ends on the threshold of the act that would complete the refusal.

14.4

“Yet Another May Succeed”: The Remainder

Victor’s last words to Walton are a renunciation that revokes itself. “Seek happiness in tranquillity, and avoid ambition, even if it be only the apparently innocent one of distinguishing yourself in science and discoveries. Yet why do I say this? I have myself been blasted in these hopes, yet another may succeed” (III.vii; ch. 24). The admonition and its retraction are spoken in a single breath. The Promethean drive survives its own refutation in the mouth of its most terrible example.

I define the *Promethean remainder* as that which persists after every refusal of Promethean power, and the novel shows it to have three components. The first is the *made being*, which persists after the refusal of further making: the creature, borne away on the ice, is alive at the novel’s close. The second is the *knowledge of making*, which persists after secrecy: Victor withholds his procedure, but the creature has read it, and the novel itself is the record that the procedure once succeeded. The third is the *desire to make*, which persists after renunciation: “yet another may succeed.” Each of the three refusals reaches one component and fails to reach the others. The sovereign veto prevents a second being but leaves the first alive and the desire intact; the democratic veto halts one quest but abolishes neither knowledge nor desire; the sacrificial veto destroys the being and its evidence but cannot touch the desire of others. The irreversibility of the first creation, which Arendt would identify as the predicament of all action, is the novel’s final word, and the remainder is its form.

CHAPTER 15

The Pandoric Return

Afterlives of the Unmade Bride

Freud described the compulsion to repeat as the return of what has been repressed but not worked through. The cultural afterlife of *Frankenstein* exhibits such a compulsion with remarkable consistency: for two centuries, adaptation after adaptation has completed the female creature that Mary Shelley left unmade. I call this phenomenon the *Pandoric return*. Its persistence is the strongest external evidence that the unmade bride, not the made creature, is the novel's unresolved center.

15.1

Completing the Bride: Whale, Levin, Garland

The return begins in silence. In Peake's *Presumption* (1823), the first stage adaptation, the creature was played as a mute by T. P. Cooke, and the playbill listed his part with a dash; Mary Shelley, attending, wrote to Leigh Hunt that "this nameless mode of naming the unnameable is rather good." James Whale's *Frankenstein* (1931) fixed the mute, lumbering creature in global memory. His sequel, *Bride of Frankenstein* (1935), performed the first great completion. Its prologue presents Mary Shelley in conversation with Byron and Percy Shelley, and the same actress, Elsa Lanchester, plays both Mary Shelley and the Bride. Author and unmade bride are embodied by one performer — the most exact visual gloss on the novel's encrypted structure ever produced. The completed Bride, brought to life, sees her intended mate and recoils with a scream; the creature, rejected, destroys the laboratory. Whale's film realizes, with startling fidelity, the third of Victor's fears: that she might "turn with disgust from him."

The two terminal possibilities held in suspension by Victor's deliberation have since been realized separately. Ira Levin's *The Stepford Wives* (1972) imagines the made woman who perfectly honours the compact: in a suburban town the husbands replace their wives with compliant replicas, and the horror is total compliance. Alex Garland's *Ex Machina* (2014) imagines the made woman who refuses it: an android, designed by

her maker and examined by a young man who believes himself her rescuer, manipulates both, kills her maker, and leaves the young man imprisoned as she walks into the world. *Ex Machina* is Victor's autonomy fear in cinematic form — a thinking and reasoning being who declines a compact made before her creation. Between Stepford and *Ex Machina* lies the full range of the Pandoric return, and the novel holds both possibilities in suspension by refusing to finish its bride.

15.2

Feminist Completions: Jackson, Gray, Lanthimos, Winterson

A distinct line of feminist rewritings completes the bride in order to give her what the novel denied: a voice, a body of her own, and a future. Shelley Jackson's hypertext *Patchwork Girl* (1995), attributed to "Mary/Shelley, & Herself," imagines that Mary Shelley secretly completed the female creature herself; author and creature become lovers, and the creature narrates her composite body in a form — linked fragments — that is itself a patchwork. Alasdair Gray's *Poor Things* (1992) is the most pointed of all. Its surgeon is named Godwin Bysshe Baxter, after Mary Shelley's father and husband; its heroine, Bella Baxter, is created when Baxter recovers the body of a pregnant woman who has drowned herself and implants in it the brain of her unborn child. The drowned bride is retrieved from the water — the Orkney basket raised from the sea — and she is her own mother and her own daughter. Against Victor's male parthenogenesis Gray sets a female autogenesis. A counter-narrative within the book, attributed to Bella under her later name, Victoria McCandless, recasts the story as that of a woman who becomes a physician and a socialist. Yorgos Lanthimos's film adaptation (2023) carried this line to a global audience. Jeanette Winterson's *Frankissstein* (2019) brings the question into the present of artificial intelligence, sex robots, and transgender embodiment, and makes explicit that the made body is now at once a commodity and a political claim.

15.3

Composite Citizens and Antigenetic Governance

Ahmed Saadawi's *Frankenstein in Baghdad* (2013) relocates the composite body to the sectarian violence of post-invasion Iraq. A junk dealer assembles a corpse from the parts of bombing victims; animated, the "Whatsitsname" sets out to avenge each victim whose part composes him, but as his avenged parts decay he must replace them with the parts of new victims, so that his justice generates the injuries it avenges. The composite citizen of a shattered polity is sustained by the violence that constituted him. Saadawi completes the political allegory that Canning and Gaskell

began: the creature as the body of the dispossessed, assembled by violence and condemned to reproduce it.

The novel's most consequential afterlife, however, lies outside literature, in the governance of technologies that can make, remake, or refuse to make life. At the Asilomar conference of February 1975, molecular biologists imposed on themselves guidelines and a period of restraint on recombinant DNA research — a collegial refusal resembling the democratic veto of Walton's crew more than the sovereign veto of Victor. The announcement in November 2018 that genome-edited twins had been born in China precipitated calls for a global moratorium on heritable human genome editing (2019) and a governance framework from the World Health Organization (2021). The precautionary principle, formulated in Principle 15 of the Rio Declaration (1992), is the institutional form of Jonas's heuristics of fear. Contemporary debate about artificial intelligence has made Victor's deliberation newly legible: its three clusters of reasons correspond with uncanny precision to what researchers now discuss as the problem of control — systems of unknown dispositions, the difficulty of binding a system to specifications fixed before its creation, and the risk of self-replication. Nick Bostrom's *Superintelligence* (2014) and Stuart Russell's *Human Compatible* (2019) are, in this respect, footnotes to the Orkney laboratory.

The novel offers this domain not a verdict but a structural warning. It does not say whether the female creature should have been made. It shows that a refusal exercised unilaterally, secretly, after an original act of creation, and without the participation of the being already made, converts a claimant into an enemy and displaces its costs onto those nearest the one who refuses. The question it bequeaths to antigenetic governance is not the Promethean question — whether to create — but the question that follows creation: what is owed to the made by those who decline to make more. Victor never asked it. He destroyed the female and offered the creature nothing in her place — neither recognition, nor a share of the world, nor a voice in the decision. The obligations of refusal are the novel's unclaimed ethical legacy.

CONCLUSION

The Author as Unmade Bride

C.1

"A Young Girl"

In the introduction to the edition of 1831 Mary Shelley poses the question her readers had been asking for thirteen years: "How I, then a young girl, came to think of, and to dilate upon, so very hideous an idea?" She answers with a narrative of origins — the wet summer, the ghost-story contest, the conversations on galvanism, the waking vision of "the pale student of unhallowed arts kneeling beside the thing he had put together" — and closes by bidding her "hideous progeny go forth and prosper." The introduction has usually been read as installing the author in the position of Victor: the maker of a monstrous offspring, anxious and defiant about her creation. Barbara Johnson (1982) and Mary Poovey (1984) have shown how much of the novel's energy derives from a woman writer's ambivalence toward her own authorship. The argument of this thesis permits a further step. The figure in the novel whose position most exactly corresponds to its author's is neither Victor nor the creature but the being Victor unmade.

Mary Wollstonecraft Godwin was conceived outside marriage by two philosophers who had argued against the institution. William Godwin and Mary Wollstonecraft were married at St Pancras on 29 March 1797 because Wollstonecraft was pregnant with their daughter: their marriage was, in the most literal sense, a compact contracted on account of her impending existence and concluded before she was born. After her mother's death she was formed according to a philosophical programme — a rational education in the household of the author of *Political Justice*, under the shadow of the author of *A Vindication of the Rights of Woman* — that preceded and designed her. At sixteen she refused the compact. In July 1814 she eloped with a married man, against the will of a father whose own philosophy had condemned marriage as a monopoly and who nevertheless repudiated her for acting upon it. She was, in the terms Victor uses on Orkney, a "thinking and reasoning animal" who refused "to comply with a compact made before her creation."

The novel encrypts this position structurally rather than biographically. Its addressee bears the author's initials and never speaks; its innermost chamber contains the letters of a motherless woman who fled her father's design for her, letters the creature copies as proof of his truth; its central act is the destruction of a female who might reason; and its mothers are all dead. The mythic grammar reconstructed in Chapter 12 supplies the key. Mary Shelley is an Athena, the motherless daughter born from the father's head — the child of a philosophy — who carries within her the swallowed intelligence of the mother. Zeus incorporated Metis so that her cunning would counsel him from within; the philosopher's daughter writes the swallowed *mētis* back into speech. The novel is the female creature's reply. What Victor feared on Orkney — that the made woman would think, reason, and refuse — is what the author did, and *Frankenstein* is the proof.

The composition of the novel was attended by deaths that make the encryption more than a figure. Mary Shelley had lost a premature daughter in March 1815, and her journal records a dream that the infant came to life again when rubbed before the fire. In the months of composition her half-sister Fanny Imlay, Wollstonecraft's elder daughter, took her own life (October 1816), and the body of Percy Shelley's first wife, Harriet, was recovered from the Serpentine (December 1816); Mary married Percy weeks later. A woman had gone into the water; the novel would put the female creature into the sea. In this light Elsa Lanchester's double role in *Bride of Frankenstein* acquires the force of an interpretation: author and unmade bride are one figure.

C.2

"Lost in Darkness and Distance"

The novel's last sentence leaves its creature alive: "He was soon borne away by the waves, and lost in darkness and distance." The pyre is promised but not lit; the remains of the female lie on the sea floor off the Orkneys; Victor is dead, and his last words have revoked his renunciation. Everything this thesis has argued is contained in that unfinished ending.

The argument may be gathered into seven propositions. The decisive act of *Frankenstein* is not the making of the creature but the unmaking of his bride, an act of antigenesis that converts the created being's grievance into enmity and sets every subsequent death in motion. Antigenesis is overdetermined by three anxieties — of propagation, of female rational autonomy, and of species succession — which the novel derives from the Godwin–Malthus controversy, from Wollstonecraft's critique of Rousseau's designed woman, and from the Hesiodic logic of succession that Darwin would generalize. The novel's mythic grammar is accordingly Olympian rather than

Promethean: Victor reenacts Zeus's motherless birth of Athena and his swallowing of Metis. The result is a Promethean chiasmus in which creator and creature exchange their positions in every register, so that the creature — fire-bringer, secret benefactor, bound and consumed — becomes the Modern Prometheus of the subtitle. The novel tests three modalities of refusal, sovereign, democratic, and sacrificial, and shows that none can annul the Promethean remainder: the being made, the knowledge of its making, and the desire to make again. The cultural afterlife of the novel is a Pandoric return, a compulsive completion of the unmade bride oscillating between compliance and refusal. And the novel encrypts its author as the bride who refused a compact made before her creation and survived her unmaking by becoming a maker.

The implications extend beyond the criticism of a single text. If the philosophical center of the founding myth of technological modernity is a refusal rather than a creation, then the ethics of the made cannot begin with the Promethean question of whether to make. It must begin with the question that follows every making and every refusal: what is owed, by those who have made and who decline to make more, to what they have already made. Mary Shelley's novel poses that question with a rigour its two centuries of interpreters, and its two centuries of imitators, have not yet matched. The creature is still on the ice, and the answer has not yet been given.

APPARATUS

Selected Bibliography

PRIMARY TEXTS

Shelley, Mary Wollstonecraft. *Frankenstein; or, The Modern Prometheus*. 3 vols. London: Lackington, Hughes, Harding, Mavor, & Jones, 1818.

———. *Frankenstein; or, The Modern Prometheus*. Revised edition. London: Henry Colburn and Richard Bentley, 1831.

———. *The Frankenstein Notebooks*. Edited by Charles E. Robinson. 2 vols. New York: Garland, 1996.

———. *The Journals of Mary Shelley, 1814–1844*. Edited by Paula R. Feldman and Diana Scott-Kilvert. 2 vols. Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1987.

———. *The Last Man*. London: Henry Colburn, 1826.

———. "The Mortal Immortal." *The Keepsake for 1834*. London, 1833.

Shelley, Mary, and Percy Bysshe Shelley. *History of a Six Weeks' Tour*. London: T. Hookham, 1817.

———. *The Original Frankenstein*. Edited by Charles E. Robinson. Oxford: Bodleian Library, 2008.

Shelley, Percy Bysshe. "On Frankenstein." *The Athenaeum*, 10 November 1832.

———. *Prometheus Unbound*. London: C. and J. Ollier, 1820.

CLASSICAL, BIBLICAL, AND PRE-MODERN SOURCES

Aeschylus (attributed). *Prometheus Bound*.

Boccaccio, Giovanni. *Genealogia deorum gentilium*, Book IV.

Cicero. *De inventione*, Book II.

Dante Alighieri. *Inferno*, Canto XXVI.

Genesis 1–4; Job 3, 38–41.

Hesiod. *Theogony*; *Works and Days*.

Lucian. *Prometheus*.

Milton, John. *Paradise Lost*. 2nd ed. London, 1674.

Ovid. *Metamorphoses*, Books I, III, X.

Pico della Mirandola, Giovanni. *Oratio de hominis dignitate*. 1486.

Pindar. *Pythian* 3; *Isthmian* 8.

Plato. *Protagoras*.

Pliny the Elder. *Natural History*, Book XXXV.

Talmud Bavli, *Sanhedrin* 38b, 65b.

Tertullian. *Apologeticum*.

PHILOSOPHICAL, SCIENTIFIC, AND LITERARY SOURCES, 1600–1900

Abernethy, John. *An Enquiry into the Probability and Rationality of Mr. Hunter's Theory of Life*. London, 1814.

Aldini, Giovanni. *An Account of the Late Improvements in Galvanism*. London, 1803.

Bacon, Francis. *Temporis partus masculus*. c. 1603.

Barruel, Augustin. *Mémoires pour servir à l'histoire du jacobinisme*. 4 vols. London, 1797–98.

Beckford, William. *Vathek*. 1786.

Blumenbach, Johann Friedrich. *Über den Bildungstrieb*. Göttingen, 1781. *De generis humani varietate nativa*. 3rd ed. Göttingen, 1795.

Burke, Edmund. *A Philosophical Enquiry into the Origin of Our Ideas of the Sublime and Beautiful*. 1757. *Reflections on the Revolution in France*. 1790. *Two Letters on the Proposals for Peace with the Regicide Directory of France*. 1796.

Butler, Samuel. "Darwin among the Machines." *The Press* (Christchurch), 13 June 1863. *Erewhon*. 1872.

Byron, George Gordon, Lord. "Prometheus" and "Darkness." 1816. *Manfred*. 1817.

Coleridge, Samuel Taylor. "The Rime of the Ancyent Marinere." *Lyrical Ballads*. 1798.

Condillac, Étienne Bonnot de. *Traité des sensations*. 1754.

Darwin, Charles. *On the Origin of Species*. London: John Murray, 1859.

Darwin, Erasmus. *The Temple of Nature*. London, 1803.

Davy, Humphry. *A Discourse Introductory to a Course of Lectures on Chemistry*. London, 1802. *Elements of Chemical Philosophy*. London, 1812.

Defoe, Daniel. *Mere Nature Delineated*. London, 1726.

Fichte, Johann Gottlieb. *Grundlage des Naturrechts*. 1796–97.

Galvani, Luigi. *De viribus electricitatis in motu musculari commentarius*. Bologna, 1791.

Gaskell, Elizabeth. *Mary Barton*. 1848.

Godwin, William. *An Enquiry Concerning Political Justice*. 1793. *Things As They Are; or, The Adventures of Caleb Williams*. 1794. *St. Leon*. 1799.

Goethe, Johann Wolfgang von. "Prometheus." c. 1774; published 1785. *Die Leiden des jungen Werthers*. 1774. *Wilhelm Meisters Lehrjahre*. 1795–96. "Der Zauberlehrling." 1797. *Faust II*. 1832.

Hegel, G. W. F. *Phänomenologie des Geistes*. 1807.

Hoffmann, E. T. A. "Der Sandmann." *Nachtstücke*. 1816.

Itard, Jean-Marc-Gaspard. *De l'éducation d'un homme sauvage*. Paris, 1801.

Kant, Immanuel. "Fortgesetzte Betrachtung der seit einiger Zeit wahrgenommenen Erderschütterungen." 1756. *Kritik der Urteilskraft*. 1790.

Lavater, Johann Kaspar. *Physiognomische Fragmente*. 1775–78. *Essays on Physiognomy*. Translated by Thomas Holcroft. London, 1789.

Lawrence, William. *Lectures on Physiology, Zoology, and the Natural History of Man*. London, 1819.

Lewis, Matthew Gregory. *The Monk*. 1796.

Locke, John. *An Essay Concerning Human Understanding*. 1690.

Malthus, Thomas Robert. *An Essay on the Principle of Population*. London, 1798; 2nd ed. 1803.

Marx, Karl, and Friedrich Engels. *Manifest der Kommunistischen Partei*. 1848.

Monboddo, James Burnett, Lord. *Of the Origin and Progress of Language*. 6 vols. 1773–92.

Peake, Richard Brinsley. *Presumption; or, the Fate of Frankenstein*. 1823.

Poe, Edgar Allan. "Ligeia." 1838. "The Facts in the Case of M. Valdemar." 1845.

Polidori, John William. *The Vampyre*. 1819.

Radcliffe, Ann. *The Mysteries of Udolpho*. 1794.

Rousseau, Jean-Jacques. *Discours sur l'origine et les fondements de l'inégalité parmi les hommes*. 1755. *Émile, ou De l'éducation*. 1762. *Du contrat social*. 1762. *Pygmalion*. 1770. *Les Confessions*. 1782–89.

Shaftesbury, Anthony Ashley Cooper, Third Earl of. "Soliloquy: or, Advice to an Author." 1710.

Stevenson, Robert Louis. *Strange Case of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde*. 1886.

Stoker, Bram. *Dracula*. 1897.

Tennyson, Alfred. "Ulysses." 1842.

Villiers de l'Isle-Adam, Auguste. *L'Ève future*. 1886.

Volney, Constantin-François. *Les Ruines, ou Méditation sur les révolutions des empires*. 1791.

Walpole, Horace. *The Castle of Otranto*. 1764.

Wells, H. G. *The Island of Doctor Moreau*. 1896.

Wollstonecraft, Mary. *A Vindication of the Rights of Men*. 1790. *A Vindication of the Rights of Woman*. 1792. *An Historical and Moral View of the Origin and Progress of the French Revolution*. 1794. *Letters Written during a Short Residence in Sweden, Norway, and Denmark*. 1796.

MODERN PHILOSOPHY AND THEORY

Agamben, Giorgio. *Homo Sacer: Il potere sovrano e la nuda vita*. Turin: Einaudi, 1995.

Arendt, Hannah. *The Human Condition*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1958.

Blumenberg, Hans. *Arbeit am Mythos*. Frankfurt: Suhrkamp, 1979.

Bostrom, Nick. *Superintelligence: Paths, Dangers, Strategies*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2014.

Butler, Judith. *Precarious Life*. London: Verso, 2004. *Frames of War*. London: Verso, 2009.

Derrida, Jacques. *Donner le temps*. Paris: Galilée, 1991. *De l'hospitalité*. Paris: Calmann-Lévy, 1997.

Detienne, Marcel, and Jean-Pierre Vernant. *Les ruses de l'intelligence: La mètis des Grecs*. Paris: Flammarion, 1974.

Fanon, Frantz. *Peau noire, masques blancs*. Paris: Seuil, 1952.

Foucault, Michel. *La volonté de savoir*. Paris: Gallimard, 1976. *"Il faut défendre la société": Cours au Collège de France, 1975–1976*. Paris: Gallimard/Seuil, 1997.

Freud, Sigmund. *Totem und Tabu*. 1913. "Das Unheimliche." 1919.

Garland-Thomson, Rosemarie. *Extraordinary Bodies*. New York: Columbia University Press, 1997. *Staring: How We Look*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2009.

Girard, René. *La violence et le sacré*. Paris: Grasset, 1972.

Haraway, Donna. "A Manifesto for Cyborgs." *Socialist Review* 80 (1985).

Honneth, Axel. *Kampf um Anerkennung*. Frankfurt: Suhrkamp, 1992.

Horkheimer, Max, and Theodor W. Adorno. *Dialektik der Aufklärung*. Amsterdam: Querido, 1947.

Jentsch, Ernst. "Zur Psychologie des Unheimlichen." 1906.

Jonas, Hans. *Das Prinzip Verantwortung*. Frankfurt: Insel, 1979.

Lacan, Jacques. "Le stade du miroir comme formateur de la fonction du Je." 1949.

Latour, Bruno. *Nous n'avons jamais été modernes*. Paris: La Découverte, 1991. "Love Your Monsters." *Breakthrough Journal* 2 (2011).

Levinas, Emmanuel. *Totalité et infini*. The Hague: Nijhoff, 1961.

Lévi-Strauss, Claude. *Les structures élémentaires de la parenté*. Paris: PUF, 1949.

Loraux, Nicole. *Les enfants d'Athéna*. Paris: Maspero, 1981.

Mauss, Marcel. "Gift, gift." 1924. "Essai sur le don." *L'Année sociologique*, 1925.

Merchant, Carolyn. *The Death of Nature*. San Francisco: Harper & Row, 1980.

Pateman, Carole. *The Sexual Contract*. Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1988.

Pesic, Peter. "Wrestling with Proteus: Francis Bacon and the 'Torture' of Nature." *Isis* 90 (1999).

Raggio, Olga. "The Myth of Prometheus: Its Survival and Metamorphoses up to the Eighteenth Century." *Journal of the Warburg and Courtauld Institutes* 21 (1958).

Rubin, Gayle. "The Traffic in Women: Notes on the 'Political Economy' of Sex." 1975.

Russell, Stuart. *Human Compatible*. New York: Viking, 2019.

Sartre, Jean-Paul. *L'être et le néant*. Paris: Gallimard, 1943.

Scholem, Gershom. "Die Vorstellung vom Golem in ihren tellurischen und magischen Beziehungen." *Eranos-Jahrbuch* 22 (1953).

Trousson, Raymond. *Le thème de Prométhée dans la littérature européenne*. Geneva: Droz, 1964.

Vernant, Jean-Pierre. *Mythe et société en Grèce ancienne*. Paris: Maspero, 1974.

CRITICISM AND SCHOLARSHIP ON FRANKENSTEIN

Baldick, Chris. *In Frankenstein's Shadow: Myth, Monstrosity, and Nineteenth-Century Writing*. Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1987.

Bloom, Harold. "Frankenstein, or the New Prometheus." *Partisan Review* 32 (1965).

Botting, Fred. *Making Monstrous: Frankenstein, Criticism, Theory*. Manchester: Manchester University Press, 1991.

Brooks, Peter. "Godlike Science/Unhallowed Arts: Language, Nature, and Monstrosity." In Levine and Knoepflmacher, 1979.

Butler, Marilyn. Introduction to *Frankenstein: The 1818 Text*. Oxford World's Classics. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1993.

Gigante, Denise. "Facing the Ugly: The Case of *Frankenstein*." *ELH* 67 (2000).

Gilbert, Sandra M., and Susan Gubar. *The Madwoman in the Attic*. New Haven: Yale University Press, 1979.

Griffith, Mark. *The Authenticity of "Prometheus Bound."* Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1977.

Homans, Margaret. *Bearing the Word*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1986.

Johnson, Barbara. "My Monster/My Self." *Diacritics* 12 (1982).

Levine, George, and U. C. Knoepflmacher, eds. *The Endurance of Frankenstein*. Berkeley: University of California Press, 1979.

Lowe-Evans, Mary. *Frankenstein: Mary Shelley's Wedding Guest*. New York: Twayne, 1993.

Malchow, H. L. "Frankenstein's Monster and Images of Race in Nineteenth-Century Britain." *Past and Present* 139 (1993).

Mellor, Anne K. *Mary Shelley: Her Life, Her Fiction, Her Monsters*. New York: Routledge, 1988.

Moers, Ellen. *Literary Women*. Garden City: Doubleday, 1976.

Moretti, Franco. *Signs Taken for Wonders*. London: Verso, 1983.

O'Flinn, Paul. "Production and Reproduction: The Case of *Frankenstein*." *Literature and History* 9 (1983).

Poovey, Mary. *The Proper Lady and the Woman Writer*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1984.

Ruston, Sharon. *Shelley and Vitality*. Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2005.

Sherwin, Paul. "*Frankenstein*: Creation as Catastrophe." *PMLA* 96 (1981).

Spivak, Gayatri Chakravorty. "Three Women's Texts and a Critique of Imperialism." *Critical Inquiry* 12 (1985).

Sterrenburg, Lee. "Mary Shelley's Monster: Politics and Psyche in *Frankenstein*." In Levine and Knoepflmacher, 1979.

Stryker, Susan. "My Words to Victor Frankenstein above the Village of Chamounix: Performing Transgender Rage." *GLQ* 1 (1994).

Young, Elizabeth. *Black Frankenstein: The Making of an American Metaphor*. New York: New York University Press, 2008.

Zonana, Joyce. "'They Will Prove the Truth of My Tale': Safie's Letters as the Feminist Core of Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein*." *Journal of Narrative Technique* 21 (1991).

COMPARATIVE LITERARY AND CINEMATIC WORKS AFTER 1900

Čapek, Karel. *R.U.R. (Rossum's Universal Robots)*. 1920.

Dick, Philip K. *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* 1968.

Garland, Alex, dir. *Ex Machina*. 2014.

Gray, Alasdair. *Poor Things*. London: Bloomsbury, 1992.

Ishiguro, Kazuo. *Never Let Me Go*. London: Faber, 2005.

Jackson, Shelley. *Patchwork Girl*. Watertown, MA: Eastgate Systems, 1995.

Lanthimos, Yorgos, dir. *Poor Things*. 2023.

Levin, Ira. *The Stepford Wives*. 1972.

Lovecraft, H. P. “Herbert West—Reanimator.” *Home Brew*, 1922.

Saadawi, Ahmed. *Frankenstein fi Baghdad*. 2013. Translated by Jonathan Wright as *Frankenstein in Baghdad*. 2018.

Whale, James, dir. *Frankenstein*. 1931. *Bride of Frankenstein*. 1935.

Winterson, Jeanette. *Frankissstein*. London: Jonathan Cape, 2019.

APPARATUS

Keywords

Mary Shelley · *Frankenstein* · antigenesis · Promethean chiasmus · Promethean remainder · Pandoric return · female creature · unmade bride · Prometheus · Pandora · Metis · Epimetheus · Hesiod · *Theogony* · succession myth · *Prometheus Bound* · *Protagoras* · *Paradise Lost* · Romanticism · Gothic fiction · horror studies · galvanism · vitalism · Abernethy–Lawrence controversy · William Godwin · Mary Wollstonecraft · Jean-Jacques Rousseau · Thomas Robert Malthus · perfectibility · sexual contract · traffic in women · recognition theory · physiognomy · aesthetic a priori · the sublime · ugliness · biopolitics · sovereignty · bare life · natality · responsibility ethics · mimetic violence · scapegoat · *Totem and Taboo* · artificial life · posthumanism · adaptation studies · precautionary principle · existential risk · reproductive politics · feminist literary criticism